

A Study Of Lexicons & Structures In The English Translations Of The Qur'an



Behrouz Foroutan

Al-Islam.org

[1] [1]

SHARES

Sub Title:

Author(s):

[Behrouz Foroutan](#) [2]

This text examines the intricacies of translating the Qur'an, exploring its necessities, challenges, and methodologies. From the miracle of its text to the unique capabilities of the Arabic language, it examines the proponents and opponents of Qur'an translation. It discusses the goal of translation and various methods employed, from literal translations to free interpretations.

The criteria for proper translation are highlighted, along with the evolving language of the Qur'an over time. Problematic wordings and structures are dissected, offering solutions and insights for conveying the message accurately. This comprehensive work serves as a guide for understanding and approaching the translation of the Qur'an, addressing linguistic complexities with clarity and precision.

[Get PDF](#) [3] [Get EPUB](#) [4] [Get MOBI](#) [5]

Topic Tags:

[Qur'an](#) [6]

Important notice:

Buy Online:

Preface

The Qur'an is the main source of Islamic belief, theology, and practice, making it profoundly important in regards to Islam. The Arabic text of the Qur'an is neither comprehensible for all Muslims around the world nor for all researchers or those who are interested in studying the text. For those who do not know Arabic, translation of the Qur'an plays a key role for conveying its message. Without a clear and correct translation, most people of the world become incapable of comprehending the message of the Qur'an.

In order to get a vision of the significance of proper Qur'an translation, we should consider the hundreds of millions who do not understand Arabic but would like to understand the Qur'an. Therefore, the translation of the Qur'an seems to be truly important. Different approaches to what "translation" actually is and the significance of the Qur'an result in a dispute between scholars and translators over the different methodologies used in translating its text.

In this writing, we have based our methodology for translation of the Qur'an on the language it uses and the message it is trying to convey. In regards to language, the Qur'an uses plain Arabic. And delivering the message of God was the main duty of God's Messenger (S) according to the Qur'an.

Accordingly, we have selected difficult words and structures used in the Qur'an and analysed them according to translations by the eight prominent translators of the Qur'an, including, Arberry, Shakir, Pickthall, Irving, Sarwar, Qara'i, Saffarzadeh, some of whom are Muslim, Shia or Sunni, and some not. Our goal was to find a method for conveying the message of the Qur'an as complete as possible.

Finally, it is my duty to express my sincere thanks to all of those who helped us including our advisors Dr. Seyd Mohammad Reza Hejazi, Dr Mohammad Reza Fakhrohani and Dr. Mohammad Rassafi also I give special thanks to Seyed Hossein Marashi who devoted his time for editing and Mohammad Amin Yazdanpanah for proof reading.

Behrouz Foroutan, Ph.D.

July 2019

Website: bforoutan.com

Email: bforoutan@gmail.com

[1] [1]

SHARES

Chapter 1: Generalities

Necessities Of Translating The Qur'an

Indeed, translation has been one of the most important issues about the Qur'an since the early centuries of Islam, because the Qur'an truly is the main source of Islamic knowledge. The translation of the Qur'an is, therefore, considered as a gateway through which all nation, regardless of language, can enter and survey the Qur'an.

The Qur'an emphasizes that it is a reminder for all mankind¹, but asking the entirety of mankind to learn Arabic to such a proficiency that would allow them to independently study and understand the Qur'an is currently absurd. According to the aforementioned verses:

Why did God send a book in Arabic for all mankind while He, the All-Knowing, knew that, considering the diversity of language and culture, it is impossible to expect everyone to learn Arabic?

Accordingly, mankind in all its diversity can receive and learn the message of the Qur'an through two ways:

- a. By studying a clear and concise translation of the Qur'an in their own language.
- b. By someone who has the right credentials and can convey the message of the Qur'an to their language.

In either case, the Qur'an must be translated first. Without translation, the majority of the people of the world will be deprived from the Qur'an's message, therefore, the translation of the Qur'an has a pivotal role in understanding the text and Islam, whether some agree or disagree.

The Opponent And The Proponent Of The Translation Of The Qur'an

To the Muslims, the Qur'an is extremely sacred. It is the most reliable book in Islam, so Muslims are very sensitive about it. While one group believes the Qur'an cannot be translated, others disagree. The issue of translation has been a subject of dispute throughout history².

Groups that believe the Qur'an cannot be translated, bring reasons such as the following.

A) The Text Of The Holy Qur'an Is A Miracle

The Qur'an has been issued by the infinite divine source; therefore, it is beyond the capability of a finite being such as Mankind to translate it. They cite verse 17:88³ and conclude that any translation is in effect a 'new' Qur'an, separate from the original one. According to the aforementioned verse, Muslims may not publish a 'new' Qur'an or something similar⁴.

The Qur'an is a miracle and the Divine words have been issued from the infinite source, God. No one is comparable to God. He sent the Qur'an to the messenger to guide mankind. Additionally, it is proof of Muhammad's (S) prophethood. Put together, any 'new' Qur'an will fail to achieve these characteristics⁵.

B) Unique Styles And The Capabilities Of The Arabic Language

Arabic is the perfect language. For this reason, different aspects of the Qur'an are displayed in Arabic. Since other languages are not as perfect as Arabic, any translation of the Qur'an may lose the styles and meaning of the text⁶:

C) The Book Of Light

The Qur'an describes itself as the “**book of light (4: 174)**”⁷. Translating the Qur'an will spoil it, that is, it will not be light anymore. Therefore, the Qur'an is untranslatable⁸.

D) Fear Of Deviation

For Muslims, the Qur'an is the holiest Book. Muslims believe the book is Divine, and has never and will never be deviated. However, that doesn't hold true for its translation. While the Arabic Qur'an cannot be deviated, the translation can, through addition or omission. This has occurred in the past at the hands of some orientalis. Although some may deliberately deviate the translation of the Qur'an, sometimes deviation occurs unintentionally. Therefore, translation can present a deviated version of the Qur'an to those who do not know Arabic.

Goal Of Translating The Qur'an

The significant difference between mankind and animal is intellect. Human beings can reason and draw conclusions. These two capabilities enable us to understand the realities of divine messages. Indeed, one must first understand, then set to analyse and judge. The Qur'an puts great emphasis on this,

وَلَقَدْ يَسَّرْنَا الْقُرْآنَ لِلذِّكْرِ فَهَلْ مِنْ مُدَكِّرٍ

“We have made the Qur'an easy to (understand and) take heed from” (54: 17; 54:32).

Today, Islam is as relevant as ever. Many people are now turning towards understanding the religion. There are many people all over the world who ask about the Qur'an and its teachings and how the deeper layers of Qur'anic verses can be accessed.

With respect to all the theories of translation, including those specifically designed for holy books, we believe that the methodologies of translating the Qur'an are strongly influenced by the intension of translators for translating the Qur'an and their personal taste towards it.

We should ask why we translate the Qur'an. What are we trying to achieve? Are we communicating its unique style or the meaning?

We should seriously doubt the statement of a translator who claims to display the entire splendour of the text of the Qur'an. The source and target languages are two completely different languages, each with its unique features. Therefore, the beauties of the texts of each language are generally exclusive to that language and culture. The syntax, lexicons, and cultures are different; thus, translation causes considerable differences between the original text and the product when it comes to eloquence and beauty. However, this does not mean that translation cannot transfer the messages of the Qur'an.

When we study the Qur'an, we repeatedly see that on one hand the verses invite the reader to ponder and pay heed to its messages, and on the other hand criticize those who refrain from using reason and neglect the messages of the Qur'an. Clearly then, since not everyone knows or can learn Arabic, the conveying of the messages and the meaning of the verses has a key role in its translation, otherwise, how can we take heed or ponder on a text we don't understand? Hence, our first priority in this translation is to transfer the messages of the verses to the target language.

Methodologies For Translating The Qur'an

Considering how the message is conveyed to the target language, translations of the Qur'an can be classified into three main categories:

1. Literal translation of the Qur'an
2. Free translation of the Qur'an
3. Translation of the meaning of a sentence from the source to a sentence in the target language.

Literal Translations Of The Qur'an

In this type of translation, the translator does his best to translate every word in the source language to a word in the target language, fretting not to miss a single word. All the words of the text are translated literally in this type of translation, so the meanings of the words sometimes seem irrelevant and the sentences are not understandable. The result is that the translator has ruined the meaning of the source text and betrayed its readers, since he both failed to transfer the meaning to the readers and confused them. There are two main reasons for these types of translations:

The translator wants to be loyal to the text of the Qur'an, imagining that their duty is fulfilled only if every word is translated. We could say they feared presenting a clear translation.

They were unaware of the arts and methods of translation.

Free Translation

This type of translation attempts to convey the message using extra information which does not exist in the source text. This is not considered a loyal translation because even though the meaning is successfully conveyed, but extra information is attributed to the text, which the reader may accidentally

think is actually part of the original text. Therefore, this type of translation is considered a kind of exegesis rather than translation. If it has been written according to the reliable sources, it can be a concise and acceptable exegesis⁹.

Translation Of The Meaning Of A Sentence Of Source Text Into A Sentence In Target Text

This is a moderate type of translation. It is neither purely literal nor free translation. This type of translation tries to convey the meaning of a sentence in the source text through a sentence or sentences in the target language. The meaning of the sentences is not ruined through the processes of translation.

The Criteria Of Proper Qur'an Translation

Just like other knowledge, such as Tafsir, translation also has its own set of rules. The Qur'an is different from others scripts and thus, has its own set of rules, which must be considered when translating the Qur'an. Conforming to these rules produces acceptable and comprehensible translations of the Qur'an, which successfully convey the Scripture's message and knowledge. It follows that disregarding these rules produces void results.

- a) Translator should be fully aware of the target and source language, interpretation of Qur'an and Qur'anic sciences, including the history of the Qur'an, theology, and jurisprudence.
- b) The translation should not be dogmatic. Translators may not ignore scientific facts and acceptable rationalities buried behind Qur'anic texts.
- c) The general principles or rules of translation should also be observed in the translation of the Qur'an.

These rules have been set in order to convey the message of the Qur'an, instead of the translator's personal opinions.

Language Of The Qur'an

Language of the Qur'an¹⁰

When we speak about the language of the Qur'an, we do not mean whether it is Arabic or English or other languages. Clearly, the Qur'an is in Arabic. We mean how scholars describe the Qur'an's method of using language. There are different sorts of opinions, such as literary, mysterious, mystical, realistic language, and etc¹¹.

When we study the Qur'an and compare it with standard writing in Saudi Arabia, we find that the language of the Qur'an is the special semi-standard language of Saudi Arabia. It is astonishing how little the difference between the Arabic of the Messenger's (S) time and that of modern-day Saudi Arabia is.

Although the Qur'an uses a special semi-standard language used by the community of the Messenger (S) and it is close to modern standard language used in Saudi Arabia, in some cases the common meanings of the lexicons are not intended. In other words, the meaning of some of the lexicons have been modified through history, since all modifications in human life directly affect language as well. Historical, social, political, scientific, and cultural changes also change language. In addition, every field including religion borrows lexicons from the common language of the community according to its needs and gives new meaning to it.

Religion, opens new fields of discussion that may have been neglected before or may have not existed all together, such as the inner matters of human, metaphysics, angels, Jinn, the hereafter, and heaven and hell. God chose the messengers from among its primary target audience¹² and they spoke the same language¹³. As a result, religions borrow lexicons from their initial target audience, although it gave new meaning to some of the lexicons, according to its needs and intentions.

In conclusion, we may say that the language of the Qur'an is not a pure common language of the people, but rather an exclusively refined common language which is close to standard Arabic, let's call it and exclusive semi-standard Qur'anic Arabic. Therefore, understanding the Qur'an requires knowledge about the exclusive language and culture of the Qur'an itself. Simply referring to the common meaning of a lexicon, while neglecting the new exclusive Qur'anic language, causes misunderstanding, mistranslation, and misinterpretation of the Qur'an. Thus, neglecting the exclusive culture of the Qur'an takes you astray and may have you attribute your own opinions to it.

The Qur'an has used a plain language to convey its message, however, it is undeniable that it uses different methodologies to guide people. For instance, laws that forbid or permit, stories, examples, and predictions. As a result, some translators use complicated words and structures in order to be loyal to whatever language they think the Qur'an is using in any given verse, whether it is literary, mystical, or whatever else. However, this approach deprives the audience from understanding the message of the verses and in some cases even fails to be loyal to the meaning by mistakenly conveying a different message than that of the verse.

When we study the Qur'an, considering its text and we see that the Qur'an has introduced the language it uses:

بَلِسَانَ عَرَبِيٍّ مُبِينٍ

“[The Qur'an has been sent] in clear Arabic language” (26: 195).

The Qur'an mentions that its language is in plain Arabic. It also says that the messengers, whose duty was delivering God's message to man, spoke and delivered the message with the language commonly used by their community.

وَمَا أَرْسَلْنَا مِنْ رَّسُولٍ إِلَّا بِلِسَانٍ قَوْمِهِ لِيُبَيِّنَ لَهُمْ

We did not send any apostle except with the language of his people, so that he might make] Our messages [clear to them.] (14:4).

In addition, the Qur'an has repeated that it is a guidance for all mankind, not just a limited group of people. It is clear that the language of the majority of the people is not literary, mystical, mysterious, and etc. When we study the syntax used in the verses of the Qur'an, we find the language and structure to be extremely close to plain standard Arabic.

This language is understandable for all Arabs, still used nowadays by the inhabitants of the Arabian Peninsula. Nevertheless, we should take into consideration that plain and standard language is one thing, deep message is another. The Qur'an has both. It is a plain language conveying deep messages and using different methodologies in a way understandable to the common people of the community. The messages go very deep and each person can learn as much as their capacity. Hence, a translator should do his best to convey the messages of the Qur'an to the target language in plain standard language and avoid literary or complicated translation. In addition, the reader has a vital role in our choice of translation method. The Qur'an is a book for all mankind, so it must be translated in a way that all mankind who speak the target language can understand the translation too.

Changes Of The Meanings Of The Words During The History

When translating, the effect of time on the meaning of words must be taken into account. Translation must be produced based on the meaning which words had at the time of revelation, otherwise, it may result in distorted translation.

We consider the word مكروه (Makruh) in the verse 17:38:

كُلُّ ذَلِكَ كَانَ سَيِّئُهُ عِنْدَ رَبِّكَ مَكْرُوهًا

Arberry: All of that the wickedness of it is hateful in the sight of thy Lord

Qara'i: The evil of all these is detestable to your Lord

Pickthall: The evil of all that is hateful in the sight of thy Lord

The word Makruh in this verse goes back to great sins such as homicide, prostitution, and etc. in the time of the Messenger (S), which is called the early years of Islam. Nowadays, however, Makruh is defined as, "All disliked deeds that are not forbidden or detested". A translator who misses this change of meaning will deliver a distorted translation. These kinds of changes are in Target and source

Misunderstanding Of Fidelity To Source And Target Texts

An important factor to always consider when translating is that the syntax and lexicon of the source and target language are different. They each belong to different cultures. Faithfulness to the source text requires faithfulness to the target language too.

Using the same structures and phrases of the source text in the target language will not work, making the translation ambiguous and sometimes wrong. This is why some parts of the translations of the Qur'an are not understandable, for instance, structures such as tamyiz, sighah al- ta'ajjub, and kam khabariyah have been improperly translated. I have discussed these types of structures in this dissertation as much as possible, Chapter three.

¹. See the following Verses of the Holy Qur'an: 6:90, 12:104, 35:1, 38:87, 18:52, 81:27.

². Rezai Isfahani, 1391 Sh, p. 79– 108.

³. The Verse says the following:

قُلْ لِّئِنْ اجْتَمَعَتِ الْإِنْسُ وَالْجِنُّ عَلَى أَنْ يَأْتُوا بِمِثْلِ هَذَا الْقُرْآنِ لَا يَأْتُونَ بِمِثْلِهِ وَلَوْ كَانَ بَعْضُهُمْ لِبَعْضٍ ظَهِيرًا

“Say if all the human being and the jinn assembled to bring a Qur'an like this they will not be able to bring it, even if they help each other”.

⁴. Biazar Shirazi 1376 Sh, 1/70.

⁵. Dhahabi 1396 A.H., 1:25.

⁶. Biazar Shirazi 1376 Sh, 1/72.

⁷. The Verse says the following:

يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ قَدْ جَاءَكُمْ بُرْهَانٌ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَأَنْزَلْنَا إِلَيْكُمْ نُورًا مُبِينًا

“O People! Indeed, a proof from your Lord has come to you and We have sent down to you a clear light.”

⁸. Muqatil b. Sulayman al-, 1423 A.H. v. 1, p. 425.

⁹. al-Dhahabi 1396 AH, 1:120.

¹⁰. See Shakir, 1389, p. 115–132

¹¹. Shakir 1431 A.H, 116.

¹². Cfr. 2:151, 3:164, 12:2.

¹³. Cfr. 14:4.

¹⁴. Isfahani 1391sh, p. 167.

[1] [1]

SHARES

Chapter 2: The Study Of Problematic Wording In The English Translations Of The Qur'an

Wording

Words and phrases are the important elements of language and play a key role in translation too. Words and phrases must be translated using appropriate equivalents. Equivalence means approximation to the original version, but we should take into consideration that finding an identical equivalent is impossible. The translator first tries to understand the communicative lexicons, then attempts to transfer and redistribute the sum total of the explicit and implicit information of the original text in a natural and clear language that the target uses.

In order to practice the teachings of the Qur'an, people must be able to understand it first. Therefore, it is vital that the meanings of the lexicons are correctly transferred to the target language, otherwise, the message of the verses will be lost. There are three types of lexicons in the Qur'an: letters, common words, and technical words.

The main elements of translation in regards to the Qur'an are vocabulary and lexicons. Instead of relying on their memory or copying the works of others, translators have to use dictionaries to translate and search the vocabulary both in Target Language and Source Language. Sometimes translators fail to hold up to this rule and thus, fail to deliver an acceptable translation or find the right equivalent.

Wording And Its Role In Transferring The Message

The common law in translating lexicons is that the target must understand it. The meaning must be precisely and clearly conveyed, otherwise, the intention of the Qur'an will not have been transferred, which is against the philosophy of its revelation and the aim of the translation.

We should divide Qur'anic lexicons into two groups:

First group: lexicons with an available equivalent, such as Pronouns: هي she or: هو he or words such as iron (حديد). This group doesn't present any specific difficulty, although some may need more than one word in order to be properly understood, such as:

- انتما: you two men or you two women
- انت: you one man or you one woman

Second group: technical Qur'anic words. It is unquestionable that some words are the product of the culture that Islam created, thus, having no equivalent in other languages, such as, Qisas, Ihram, زكاة, and Zakat.

How can such words, products of an Islamic culture fed by Divine mercy, be translated to other languages that are distant from the Islamic culture? We will attempt to answer this question by explaining the word 'Qisas'

Although Arabic dictionaries are helpful, but they are not enough for translating such technical words. We must refer to the Qur'an and Hadith. The word of Qisas has been used in the following verses:

الشَّهْرُ الْحَرَامُ بِالشَّهْرِ الْحَرَامِ وَالْحُرُمَاتُ قِصَاصٌ فَمَنْ اعْتَدَى عَلَيْكُمْ فَاعْتَدُوا عَلَيْهِ بِمِثْلِ مَا اعْتَدَى عَلَيْكُمْ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الْمُتَّقِينَ

Holy month for holy month, and punishment for committing forbidden deeds, therefore, whoever fights you, fight against them in the manner that they fought you, and be pious, and [you should] know that God is with the pious [and protects them] (2: 194).

وَكُتِبْنَا عَلَيْهِمْ فِيهَا أَنَّ النَّفْسَ بِالنَّفْسِ وَالْعَيْنَ بِالْعَيْنِ وَالْأَنْفَ بِالْأَنْفِ وَالْأُذُنَ بِالْأُذُنِ وَالسِّنَّ بِالسِّنِّ وَالْجُرُوحَ قِصَاصٌ فَمَنْ تَصَدَّقَ بِهِ فَهُوَ كَفَّارَةٌ لَهُ وَمَنْ لَمْ يَحْكَمْ بِمَا أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ فَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الظَّالِمُونَ

And We prescribed for them in [the Torah, concerning the law of al- Qisas that] a life for a life, an eye for an eye, a nose for a nose, an ear for an ear, a tooth for a tooth, and [there are also] legal retribution for wounds. But if someone gives up [his right of al-Qisas], it will be an atonement for him. [You should know that] whoever does not judge with what God has sent down [in fact], they are the wrongdoers (5:45).

وَلَكُمْ فِي الْقِصَاصِ حَيَاةٌ يَا أُولِي الْأَلْبَابِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ

O you, the wise! There is life for you in Qisas that you may be God wary (2: 179).

There is some explicit and implicit meaning concerning the word Qisas. The English language does not have an accurate equivalent for this word, so in order to convey the Qur'anic meaning and Divine intention of Qisas, we must clarify its hidden meaning according to those verses:

Qisas is in response to an aggression, not punishment. A slap on the face delivered wrongfully can be reattributed with a slap on the face of the aggressor, but the capital punishment for a murderer has no retribution, since it is not an aggression even if the heirs of the criminal disagree.

On one hand God invite people to observe the law of Qisas and asks the intellectual think concerning it because the Qisas prevents the criminal to continue their wrong deeds and teaches a lesson for the other to learn the outcome of aggression while it brings life and peace to the human being's society on the contrary the retaliation brings insecurity and hatred.

God invites people to observe the law of Qisas because it acts as a lesson and discourages aggression, resulting in security and peace in the society. On the contrary, retaliation and revenge bring insecurity and cause hatred.

Qisas is done when the criminal intentionally incurs the harms to the other one or intentionally has killed the other, so this law prevents and punishes the criminals and wrong doers, so says Qisas bring life (peace and security) for you, and it is worth adding that condition of Qisas and how it should be done it has been clarified in Qur'anic teachings. While the retaliation has not a law and it is outcome of wrath.

Qisas is in response to intentional harm. Thus, it prevents crime by punishing criminals. According to the Qur'an, Qisas brings life (i. e. peace and security). How Qisas should be executed has been clarified in Qur'anic teachings. Meanwhile, retaliation and revenge have no law, they are the outcome of wrath. However, some translators including Ali Quli Qara'i, Pickthall, Arberry, and some other translators have translated Qisas as retaliation or revenge or other equivalents. In English dictionaries, 'retaliation' and 'reveng' and their likes convey a negative meaning, but Qisas does not have a negative meaning in the Qur'anic culture. E.g.

Webster's New Third International Unabridged Dictionary:

Retaliation:

Etymology: Latin *retaliatus* (past participle of *retaliare* to retaliate) + English *-ion*:

An act of retaliating: requital; especially: return of evil for evil

Oxford Thesaurus

Retaliation:

Revenge, vengeance, reprisal, retribution, requital, recrimination, repayment; response, reaction, reply, counter-attack; archaic a Roland for an Oliver.

Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English (4th Ed):

Retaliation:

Action against someone who has done something bad to you.

So, it is clear that Qisas in Qur'anic culture has one certain meaning while the literal translation of this word may convey negative meaning to the reader and destroy the image of Divine commands. So, we see the importance of the lexicon in the translating of the Qur'an. We study the two other words to see differences in the Qur'anic words and its translation

Clearly, we see that meaning of Qisas is different from the equivalents which translators have decided to

give. We shall continue this section by examining the word Tawaf (طواف). Tawaf has two meanings:

In some verses this word has been applied in its literal meaning:

Surah At-Tur, 52:24 -

وَيَطُوفُ عَلَيْهِمْ غِلْمَانٌ لَهُمْ كَأَنَّهُمْ لُؤْلُؤٌ مَكْنُونٌ

Qara'i: They will be waited upon by youths, their own, as if they were guarded pearls

Pickthall: And there go round, waiting on them menservants of their own, as they were hidden pearls

Surah Al-Waqiya, 56: 170 -

يَطُوفُ عَلَيْهِمْ وِلْدَانٌ مُخَلَّدُونَ

Qara'i: They will be waited upon by immortal youth.

Pickthall: There wait on them immortal youths

Arberry: Immortal youths going round about them

The meaning of يَطُوفُ in this group of verses means “walking around in order to provide service to those who live in heaven” ¹. Those who shall reside in heaven, will have servants. Hence, literal translation such as ‘waited by’ or ‘going round’ be may be sufficient to convey the proper meaning of the verse. That doesn’t hold true for the second group of verses, in which the word Tawaf has been used in its technical meaning.

In the second group of verses, Tawaf has been born from the Qur’anic culture. When translating يطوف بالمروة or المروة بالصفا, both of which are technical Qur’anic words going back to exclusive Islamic teachings, the challenges reveal themselves.

Surah Al-Baqara, 2: 158 -

إِنَّ الصَّفَا وَالْمَرْوَةَ مِنْ شَعَائِرِ اللَّهِ فَمَنْ حَجَّ الْبَيْتَ أَوْ اعْتَمَرَ فَلَا جُنَاحَ عَلَيْهِ أَنْ يَطُوفَ بِهِمَا وَمَنْ تَطَوَّعَ خَيْرًا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ شَاكِرٌ عَلِيمٌ

Qara'i: Indeed, ʿAfa and Marwah are among Allah's sacraments. So whoever makes hajj to the House, or performs the Umrah, there is no sin upon him to circuit between them. Should anyone do good of his own accord, then Allah is indeed appreciative, all-knowing.

Pickthall: Lo! [The mountains] Al-ʿAfa and Al-Marwah are among the indications of Allah. It is therefore no sin for him who is on pilgrimage to the House (of God) or visited it, to go around them (as the pagan custom is). And he who doeth good of his own accord (for him), lo! Allah is Responsive, Aware.

Arberry: ʿAfa and Marwa are among the way marks of God so whosoever makes the Pilgrimage to the House, or the Visitation, it is no fault in him to circumambulate them and whoso volunteers good, God is All grateful, All knowing.

Each translator has used a different word for tawaf. In Islamic culture, tawaf is used in يطوف بالكعبة or يطوف بالصفة و المروه to describe two different Islamic deeds, however, these translations will not convey these meanings to their audience well.

Comparative Study Of Problematic Wordings

A translator deals with three types of lexicons when translating the Qur'an. The first type consists of the usual words, which have accurate equivalents in the target language, e.g., pronouns. This type does not present much of a challenge.

The second type consists of exclusive Qur'anic words. Since these words originate in Qur'anic culture, they have no equivalent in the target language. Making up equivalents will confuse the reader, so these words must be transliterated, not translated, with an explanation in the footnote. Some examples of this category are: Qisas, taqwa, ka'bah, Hajj Umrah and tamattu',

The third type consists of words with more than a meaning. The text and commentary of the Qur'an reveal which meaning is meant. In this category, the meaning must be explained in the translation, otherwise, it causes ambiguity or misunderstanding. We have discussed and analysed some of these words as much as it was possible for us:

Ajal

أَجَل - Ajal

Ajal means the specified time of something. One example is the specified time of a person's death². A look at different verses shows that this word has different meanings according to its respective verse, which must not be neglected by the translator:

Note: أَجَلًا وَّ أَجَلٌ مُّسَمًّى in this verse are two different facts according to the commentaries of the Qur'an. أَجَلًا: A time during which mankind live. أَجَلٌ مُّسَمًّى: certain time of death which is not changed).

Surah Al-An'am, 6:2 -

هُوَ الَّذِي خَلَقَكُمْ مِنْ طِينٍ ثُمَّ قَضَىٰ أَجَلًا وَأَجَلٌ مُّسَمًّى عِنْدَهُ ثُمَّ أَنْتُمْ تَمْتَرُونَ

Shakir: He it is who created you from clay, then He decreed a term (life time) and there is a term named with Him.

Irving: He is the One Who has created you all from clay; then fixed a term. A deadline has been set by Him, yet you go on doubting!

Saffarzadeh: Allah is the One Who created you of clay, then ordained the term of your life and in His Presence is The Knowledge of, but thereafter you people doubt about The Truth.

Qara'i: It is He who created you from clay, then ordained the term of your life the specified term is with Him and yet you are in doubt.

Pickthall: He it is who hath created you from clay, and hath decreed a term for you. A term is fixed with Him. Yet still ye doubt!

Sarwar: It is He who has created you from clay to live for a life-time and the span of your life is only known to Him. You are still suspicious!

Yusuf Ali: He it is who created you from clay, and then decreed a stated term for you. And there is with Him another determined term; yet ye doubt within yourselves.

Arberry: It is He who created you of clay, then determined a term life time (and a term is stated with Him); yet thereafter you doubt.

Ayat, 7:34; 4:77; 13:38;7: 135 –

وَلِكُلِّ أُمَّةٍ أَجَلٌ فَإِذَا جَاءَ أَجْلُهُمْ لَا يَسْتَأْخِرُونَ سَاعَةً وَلَا يَسْتَقْدِمُونَ

قَالُوا رَبَّنَا لِمَ كَتَبْتَ عَلَيْنَا الْقِتَالَ لَوْ لَا أَخَّرْتَنَا إِلَى أَجَلٍ قَرِيبٍ

مَا كَانَ لِرَسُولٍ أَنْ يَأْتِيَ بِآيَةٍ إِلَّا بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ لِكُلِّ أَجَلٍ كِتَابٌ

فَلَمَّا كَشَفْنَا عَنْهُمْ الرِّجْزَ إِلَى أَجَلٍ هُمْ بِالْعُوهِ إِذَا هُمْ يَنْكُتُونَ

Akhadh

أَخَذَ - Akhadh

(Akhadh) literally means 'seized', but the meaning differs when it is collocated with different words³.

Akhadh should be translated according to the text it has been used in, otherwise if it is translated literally, the meaning of the verse will not be correct or understandable. We consider the different meanings and usages of this word in the Qur'an and the translations to work out a proper equivalent for every case:

a. Make, Take

Surah Ali 'Imran, 3:81 –

وَإِذْ أَخَذَ اللَّهُ مِيثَاقَ النَّبِيِّينَ

Shakir, Pickthall, Sarwar: when Allah made a covenant with..., Irving: So, God accepted an agreement from the prophets.

Saffarzadeh: When Allah took the covenant of The Messengers.

Qara'i, Arberry: When Allah took a compact concerning the prophets.

Yusuf Ali: Allah took the covenant of the prophets.

Analysis:

The word (akhadh) added to the word (mithaq) means 'to take or make covenant or compact', even though the literal meaning of (akhadh) means seize. The translation of Irving is incorrect. The rest are acceptable.

b. Take Away, Destroy, Damage, Remove

Surah Al-An'am, 6:46 –

إِنْ أَخَذَ اللَّهُ سَمْعَكُمْ وَأَبْصَارَكُمْ

Irving: if God should snatch away your hearing and your eyesight

Shakir, Saffarzadeh, Qara'i, Pickthall: if Allah takes away your Hearing and sight

Qara'i, Yusuf Ali: should Allah take away your hearing and your sight

Sarwar: if God was to disable your hearing and vision and veil your hearts

Arberry: If God seizes your hearing and sight

Analysis:

The meaning of akhadha al Samm' wa al- Absar in the aforementioned verse means 'making them deaf and blind'⁴. God warns those who oppose Him that no one can give them their hearing and sight if it is destroyed by God. As we can see, however, some have translated this verse literally, sometimes successfully conveying the message and sometimes not. For instance, seize is the literal meaning of akhada, but it seems that words such as 'take away' or 'disable' can convey the meaning of the source text into the target text better.

c. Seize, Take, Drag

Surah Al-'Ara'af, 7: 150 –

أَخَذَ بِرَأْسِ أَخِيهِ يَجُرُّهُ إِلَيْهِ

Shakir, Irving, Saffarzadeh, Qara'i, Pickthall, Yusuf Ali: he seized his brother by the head, dragging him towards him

Sarwar: grabbed ...

Arberry: ...laid hold of his brother's head.

Analysis:

The literal translation of this word is intended in this verse, so it seems all of the translators are correct.

d. Choose, Pick Up

Surah Al-'Ara'af, 7: 172 –

وَإِذْ أَخَذَ رَبُّكَ مِنْ بَنِي آدَمَ مِنْ ظُهُورِهِمْ ذُرِّيَّتَهُمْ

Shakir, Pickthall: And when your Lord brought forth from the children of Adam, from their backs, their descendants...

Irving: When your Lord took their offspring from the Children of Adam's loins...

Saffarzadeh: when Your Creator and Nurturer brought forth From the Children of `Adam, from their Loins.

Arberry, Qara'i: When your Lord took from the Children of Adam, from their loins

Sarwar: When your Lord asked all the offspring of Adam) before their birth

Yusuf Ali: When thy Lord drew forth from the Children of Adam

Analysis:

In general, it means taking something from something apart as if they are separated.⁵ According to different exegesis this word has been interpreted in different ways for the above verse. However, it seems that when akhadha comes with “ظُهُورِهِمْ ذُرِّيَّتَهُمْ”, finding a proper equivalent is not difficult. In this example, the word akhada conveys the meaning of (chose) and it seems that ‘bring forth’ and ‘take’ can convey such a meaning.

e. Strike

Surah Hud, 11:67 –

وَأَخَذَ الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا الصَّيْحَةَ

Shakir: the rumbling overtook those who were unjust;

Pickthall: the awful Cry overtook those who did wrong (

Yusuf Ali: The (mighty) Blast overtook the wrong-doers;

Irving: The Blast caught those who had been doing wrong,

Saffarzadeh: a Divine Outcry overtook the evil-doers;

Qara’i: The Cry seized those who were wrongdoers,

Sarwar: A blast struck the unjust.

Arberry: And the evildoers were seized by the Cry Blast

Analysis:

Al-ʿayha is interpreted as a sort of punishment striking the wrongdoers, but words such as seize and catch, which are literal translations, and words like overtake do not imply punishment in standard English, although they are not wrong either.

f. Punishment

Surah Hud, 11:102 –

وَكَذَلِكَ أَخْذُ رَبِّكَ إِذَا أَخَذَ الْقُرَىٰ وَهِيَ ظَالِمَةٌ إِنَّ أَخْذَهُ أَلِيمٌ شَدِيدٌ

Shakir: And such is the punishment of your Lord when He punishes the towns while they are unjust surely His punishment is painful, severe

Irving: Even so will your Lord seize things when He takes over any towns while they are doing wrong; His seizing will be painful, severe.

Saffarzadeh: Such is the overtaking of your Creator and Nurturer: When He overtakes the wrongdoers of the towns, His Punishment is painful and severe.

Qara'i: Such is the seizing of your Lord when He seizes the townships that are wrongdoing. Indeed His seizing is painful, severe.

Pickthall: Even thus, is the grasp of thy Lord when He grasped the townships while they are doing wrong. Lo! His grasp is painful, very strong.

Sarwar: Thus, was the punishment of your Lord when He punished the unjust people of the towns. The punishment of your Lord is certainly severe.

Yusuf Ali: Such is the Chastisement of thy Lord when He chastises communities in the midst of their wrong: grievous, indeed, and severe is His chastisement.

Surah Al-Muzammil, 73:16 –

فَأَخَذْنَاهُ أَخْذًا وَبِيلًا

Shakir: so We laid on him a violent hold, Irving: so We seized him mercilessly;

Saffarzadeh: so We seized him with a Destructive calamity;

Qara'i: so We seized him with a terrible seizing.

Pickthall: We seized him with no gentle grip.

Sarwar: We seized him with a severe retribution

Yusuf Ali: so We seized him with a heavy Punishment.

Arberry: so We seized him remorselessly

Analysis:

In both of the aforementioned verses (akhadh) means punish, but some of the translators translated it literally, the meaning is not transferred correctly and therefore the readers are confused. Words such as seize, hold, overtake, and grasp are neither clear nor correct. We suggest the following translation:

“Thus, it’s the punishment of your Lord when He (wills to) destroy (the wrongdoers of) a town while they wrong. Indeed, His punishment is painful and severe.”

“But Pharaoh disobeyed the messenger (and rebelled against him), so We punished him heavily.”

g. Take

Surah Yunus, 10:24 –

حَتَّىٰ إِذَا أَخَذَتِ الْأَرْضُ زُخْرُفَهَا وَازَّيَّنَتْ....

Shakir: until when the earth puts on its golden raiment and it becomes garnished.

Irving: when the earth takes on its trimmings and looks attractive,

Saffarzadeh: when the earth has taken on her ornaments and is flourished.

Qara’i: When the earth puts on its luster and is adorned,

Pickthall: when the earth hath taken on her ornaments and is embellished

Sarwar: When the land becomes fertile and pleasant

Yusuf Ali: till the earth is clad with its golden ornaments and is decked out (in beauty): the people to whom it belongs think they have all powers of disposal over it.

Arberry: till, when the earth has taken on its glitter and has decked itself fair.

Analysis:

The word (akhadh) here means put on and take on and it seems the translations are acceptable.

Ahl

Ahl – اهل

This word has an extensive range of meaning, including close relative, family, dweller, follower, those who belong or adhere to a place, etc.⁶. This word collocates with other words and produces an even greater variety of meaning, making it troublesome for translators. Therefore, the text, collocations, and exegesis of this verse must be studied in order to understand its appropriate meaning and find a correct equivalent. We shall study this word and its different collocations and examine what equivalents translators have found to be appropriate.

Ahl Al-Kitab, Ahl Al-Injil

(Ahl) meaning those who believe in a creed or teachings of a book or those who follow it. This example refers to Christians and Jews who believe in the Gospel and Torah respectively. Translators use the expression ‘People of Book’. (Ahl) here means people.

أَهْلُ الْكِتَابِ ، أَهْلُ الْإِنْجِيلِ

Yusuf Ali, Arberry, Sarwar, Irving, Saffarzadeh, Qara'i: People of the Book

Pickthall: People of the Scripture,

Shakir: followers of the book

The translators used two different equivalents to the word of (Ahl) in this group: people and followers. Although ‘follower’ seems to be more precise, but ‘people’ is not wrong either, because English-speaking audience knows that “People of Book” refers to Christians and Jews while “People of Gospel” refers to Christians. Both translations are acceptable.

The People Of...

(Ahl) meaning people, dwellers, those who live in a place

أَهْلُ الْقُرَى، أَهْلُ قَرْيَةٍ ، أَهْلُ يَنْثَرِبَ ، أَهْلُ الْمَدِينَةِ

Qara'i, Saffarzadeh, Shakir, Pickthall, Sarwar, Yusuf Ali: the people of ...

Irving: townsfolk.

This has also been translated correctly by all translators.

Member Of The Family

أَهْلُ الْبَيْتِ

We see the translation of (Ahl) in this collocation as follows:

Irving: people in this house.

Shakir, Pickthall, Sarwar, Yusuf Ali, Arberry: people of the house.

Qara'i: members of the household.

Analysis:

(Ahl) means member of family. In verse (33:33), it exclusively refers to specific members of the Messenger's (S) family while in verse (11:33) it means members of Abraham's family⁷.

It seems Qara'i's translation is more understandable than the rest in addition to being close to the meaning of the words in the source language.

People Who Remind God

أَهْلَ الذِّكْرِ

Shakir: the Followers of the Reminder; Irving: people with long memories;

affarzadah: the learned men of the previous religions;

Qara'i: the People of the Reminder;

Pickthall: the followers of the Reminder;

Sarwar: the People of the Book;

Yusuf Ali: those who possess the Message.

Arberry: the people of the Remembrance

Analysis:

The word (Ahl) with (al-Dhikr) refers to a special group whom should be referred to when God's message seems unclear. This definition could mean a group of Christians for the Christians or Jews for the Jews too⁸. But in this verse a specific group of trusted and divine people who are qualified to be inquired about God's law is meant, therefore, it would be better to transliterate the word (Ahl al-Dhikr) instead of translating it.

According to this, the translation of Sarwar and Irving is incorrect and other translations need further clarification, otherwise they shall fail to correctly convey the meaning of this collocation in this verse.

The Dwellers Of Fire, Hell

Surah Saad, 38:64 –

أَهْلُ النَّارِ

Qara'i: the Inmates of the Fire; Irving: the people in the Fire,

Saffarzadeh, Arberry: the inhabitants of the Fire,

Pickthall: dwellers in the Fire;

Sarwar: the dwellers of hell fire, Yusuf Ali: the People of the Fire.

Analysis:

Ahl an-Nar are wrongdoers who will dwell in the fire in the hereafter for whatever wrong deeds they committed. It seems that the translations offered here are acceptable, except for Yusuf Ali whose translation could be improved since it appears to be only a literal translation.

People Who Observe Taqwa

Surah Al-Muddaththir, 74:56 –

أَهْلُ التَّقْوَى وَأَهْلُ الْمَغْفِرَةِ

Shakir: He is worthy to feared and worthy to forgive, Irving: He is Entitled to be heeded, as well as Entitled to grant forgiveness!

Saffarzadeh: Allah is The Source of Righteousness and The Owner of Forgiveness.

Qara'i: He is worthy of] your [being wary] of Him [and He is worthy to forgive.

Pickthall: He is the fount of fear. He is the fount of Mercy.

Sarwar: He alone is worthy of being feared and He is the Source of Forgiveness.

Yusuf Ali: He is the Lord of Righteousness, and the Lord of Forgiveness.

Arberry: He is Worthy to be feared, Worthy to forgive.

Analysis:

Here (Ahl) means 'worthy of'. This verse says that God deserves to be feared and He deserves to show forgiveness⁹. According to what was mentioned before, it seems the translations of Shakir, Qara'i, and Arberry are more acceptable than the rest. The rest need to be corrected.

Bu'dan

Bu'dan – بُعْداً

Surah Hud, 11:44 –

بُعْداً لِلْقَوْمِ الظَّالِمِينَ

Shakir: Away with the unjust people;

Irving: Away with such wrongdoing folk!"

Saffarzadeh: Away with The wrongdoers!

Qara'i: Away with the wrongdoing lot!

Pickthall: A far removal for wrongdoing folk!

Sarwar: Curse to the nation the unjust/ oppressive.

Yusuf Ali: Away with those who do wrong

Arberry: Away with the people of the evildoers!

Analysis:

The word of Bu'dan is used in the form of prayer and through which God curses the wrongdoers. God states that the wrongdoers are far from God's mercy [10](#), so the translations should be in the form of a prayer and also convey that they are far from God's mercy. None of the translations seem to be in the form of prayer, so this is suggested instead: "May the wrongdoers be away (from God's mercy)."

The suggested translation for all the verse 11:44 is as follows:

وَقِيلَ يَا أَرْضُ ابْلَعِي مَاءَكِ وَيَا سَمَاءُ أَقْلِعِي وَغِيضَ الْمَاءُ وَقُضِيَ الْأَمْرُ وَاسْتَوَتْ عَلَى الْجُودِيِّ ۖ وَقِيلَ بُعْداً لِلْقَوْمِ
الظَّالِمِينَ

And it was said, "O earth! Swallow up your water. O sky! Stop (raining)." And the water came down and the command was carried out and the ship rested on the Mount of Judi. It was said, "May the wrongdoers be away (from God's mercy)!"

Bayt

بَيْت - Bayt

Bayt has been used for different meanings in the Qur'an. We shall bring one example for each meaning it has and their translation and an analysis of the translations:

House

Surah Aali-'Imran 3:96 -

إِنَّ أَوَّلَ بَيْتٍ وُضِعَ لِلنَّاسِ لَلَّذِي بِبَكَّةَ مُبَارَكًا وَهُدًى لِّلْعَالَمِينَ

Shakir, Irving, Saffarzadeh, Qara'i, Sarwar, Yusuf Ali, Arberry: first house,

Pickthall: the first Sanctuary.

Analysis:

Bayt has been used in its literal meaning here. All the translators except Pickthall have translated this word correctly. Meanwhile, Pickthall's translation is neither literal nor does it convey the word's true implication.

Family

Surah Al-Qasas, 28: 12 -

هَلْ أَدُلُّكُمْ عَلَىٰ أَهْلِ بَيْتٍ يَكْفُلُونَهُ لَكُمْ وَهُمْ لَهُ نَاصِحُونَ

Shakir: ...Shall I point out to you the people of a house who will take care of him for you and they will be benevolent to him?

Irving: Shall I lead you to a family who will look after him for you? They will take good care of him.

Saffarzadeh: Do you want Me to introduce a caring nurse for your Baby?"

Qara'i: Shall I show you a household that will take care of him for you and will be his well-wishers?

Pickthall: Shall I show you a household who will rear him for you and take care of him?

Sarwar: May I show you a family who can nurse him for you with kindness? Yusuf Ali: Shall I point out to you the people of a house that will nourish and bring him up for you and take care of him?

Arberry: Shall I direct you to the people of a household who will take charge of him for you and look after him?

Analysis:

Bayt here means family, and Ahl al-Bayt means members of a family¹¹. The verse is about the story of Moses¹².

Household Of The Messenger Of Islam (S)

Surah Al-Ahzab, 33:33 –

إِنَّمَا يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ لِيُذْهِبَ عَنْكُمُ الرِّجْسَ أَهْلَ الْبَيْتِ وَيُطَهِّرَكُمْ تَطْهِيراً

Shakir: Allah only desires to keep away the uncleanness from you, O people of the House!

Irving: God merely wants to remove any blight from you, since you are People of the (Prophet's) House, and to cleanse you thoroughly.

Saffarzadeh: Verily, Allah's Will is to remove away impurity from You, the people of the Messenger's Household and to purify you with a thorough purification

Qara'i: Indeed Allah desires to repel all impurity from you, O People of the Household, and purify you with a thorough purification.

Pickthall: Allah's wish is but to remove uncleanness far from you, O Folk of the Household, and cleanse you with a thorough cleansing.

Sarwar: People of the house, God wants to remove all kinds of uncleanness from you and to purify you thoroughly.

Yusuf Ali: And Allah only wishes to remove all abomination from you, ye members of the Family, and to make you pure and spotless.

Arberry: And obey God and His Messenger (S) People of the House, God only desires to put away from you abomination and to cleanse you.

Analysis:

According to the commentaries of the Qur'an, Bayt here means the house of the Messenger (S) of Islam. The "people of the house" refers to specific members of the house of the Messenger (S), which is a matter of dispute between the Shia and Sunni's scholars. Regardless of who the members of the house of the Messenger (S) whom have been purified by God are, it seems it is the duty of the translator

to mention that Bayt means the House of the Messenger (S) here, otherwise it may be confusing if 'house' is brought without mentioning which house is meant. Some translators have added this explanation and some haven't.

[Ka`bah](#)

Surah Al-Baqara, 2: 158 -

إِنَّ الصَّفَا وَالْمَرْوَةَ مِنْ شَعَائِرِ اللَّهِ فَمَنْ حَجَّ الْبَيْتَ أَوْ اعْتَمَرَ فَلَا جُنَاحَ عَلَيْهِ أَنْ يَطَّوَّفَ بِهِمَا وَمَنْ تَطَوَّعَ خَيْرًا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ شَاكِرٌ عَلِيمٌ

Shakir: Surely the Ṣafa and the Marwa [13](#) are among the signs appointed by Allah; so whoever makes a pilgrimage to the House or pays a visit (to it), there is no blame on him if he goes round them both; and whoever does good spontaneously, then surely Allah is Grateful, Knowing.

Irving: Ṣafa and Marwa are some of God's way marks. Anyone who goes on Pilgrimage to the House or visits] it...

Saffarzadeh: Verily, Ṣafa and Marwah are some of Allah's Way marks; whoever, therefore Makes a pilgrimage to Ka`bah or Performs Umrah there shall be no Blame on him to go round them.

Qara'i: Indeed, Ṣafa and Marwah are among Allah's sacraments. So whoever makes hajj to the House, or performs the" umrah.

Pickthall: Lo! (The mountains) As-Ṣafa and Al-Marwah are among the indications of Allah. It is therefore no sin for him who is on pilgrimage to the House (of God) or visited it, to go around them) as the pagan custom is.

Sarwar: Ṣafa and Marwah) names of two places in Mecca (are reminders of God. It is no sin for one who visits the Sacred House) in Mecca (to walk seven times between) Ṣafa and Marwah. Yusuf Ali: Behold! Ṣafa and Marwa are among the Symbols of Allah. So if those who visit the House in the Season or at other times, should compass them round, it is no sin in them.

Arberry: Ṣafa and Marwa are among the way marks of God so whosoever makes the Pilgrimage to the House, or the Visitation...

Analysis:

In this verse, Bayt refers to the House of God in Mecca, known as ka`bah. Although there is evidence in the verse of what Bayt means here, nevertheless, translating Bayt literally may cause some confusion for the reader. The recommendation here is to translate Bayt in an understandable way, such as some translator have done using the following words: Ka`bah, The Sacred House (in Mecca), the House (of

God).

Taht

Taht - تَحْتَ

The word (تَحْتَ: taht) literally means under, beneath, but literal translation of this word in some verses may cause ambiguity, such as verses: 2:25; 2:266; 3: 15; 3: 136; 3: 195; 3: 198; 4: 13; 4:57; 4: 122; 5: 12; 5:85; 5: 119; 9:72; 13:35 and more. We shall analyse one of these verses.

Surah Ta Ha, 20:76 -

جَنَّاتُ عَدْنٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ خَالِدِينَ فِيهَا وَ ذَلِكَ جَزَاءُ مَنْ تَزَكَّى

Shakir: The gardens of perpetuity, beneath which rivers flow, to abide therein and this is the reward of him who has purified himself)

Irving: the gardens of Eden through which rivers flow, to live in forever.

Saffarzadeh: In the Gardens of Eternity wherein Streams flow they shall dwell forever;

Qara'i: the Gardens of Eden, with streams running in them.

Pickthall: Gardens of Eden underneath which rivers flow.

Arberry: underneath which.

Sarwar: wherein

Yusuf Ali: Gardens of Eternity which they will enter: beneath them flow

Analysis:

As we see, literal translation of taht distorts the meaning of the verse, 'rivers that are under gardens'. What the verse actually means is gardens through which rivers flow, therefore words such as wherein and through are more appropriate for taht in such verses.

As-hab

As-hab - أَصْحَاب

(As-hab) is driven from (s-h-b) (ص ح ب): (14)

The meaning changes when it is collocated with other words, although it generally means colleague,

companion, those who are with someone¹⁵ or something¹⁶ regardless of whether the companion is good or not¹⁷. Using these words may cause confusion or make the translation seem strange. We shall examine the translation of this word in different collocations and attempt to find an appropriate equivalents for them. Despite the variety that collocations cause, in all cases the meaning of ‘being together’ is always true.

As-hab Al-Jannah, As-hab An-Nar

Surah Al-‘Araf, 7:44 –

أَصْحَابُ الْجَنَّةِ أَصْحَابُ النَّارِ

Shakir: the Dwellers of the Garden, the Inmates of the Fire.

Irving, Qara’i: inhabitants of the Garden, the inmates of the Fire;

Saffarzadeh: the companions of the Paradise – the companions of The Fire;

Pickthall: the dwellers of the Garden – the dwellers of the Fire;

Sarwar: The people of Paradise – the dwellers of the fire;

Arberry: Inhabitants of Paradise– the Inhabitants of the Fire;

Yusuf Ali: The Companions of the Garden– the Companions of the Fire.

Analysis:

In these collocations (As-hab) means those who dwell, live, are imprisoned, stay, and etc. somewhere. In short, it means to be somewhere. Therefore, translator who translated the (As-hab) to dwellers, inmates, or inhabitants have successfully conveyed the meaning clearly compared to those who used literal translations such as companions, people of, and etc. The same story applies to the following collocations:

أَصْحَابِ السَّعِيرِ

أَصْحَابَ الرَّسِّ

أَصْحَابُ الْكَهْفِ وَالرَّقِيمِ

أَصْحَابُ السَّفِينَةِ

أَصْحَابُ الْقَرْيَةِ

أَصْحَابُ الْأَيْكَةِ

It is worth mentioning that sometimes these collocations refer to a certain people, referring to certain names of places and people. In such cases, transliteration isn't wrong.

As'hab Musa

Surah ash-Shu'ara', 26:61 –

أَصْحَابُ مُوسَى

Shakir, Irving, Saffarzadeh, Qara'i, Sarwar, Arberry: the companions of Moses,

Pickthall: those with Moses;

Yusuf Ali: the people of Moses.

Analysis:

(As-hab) in this collocation means those who were with Moses, regardless of whether they were obedient or not. We know historically that even though they are called the people of Moses, but they were not all of his people¹⁸. In conclusion, it seems translating this word to (companion) is better than its alternatives.

As'hab Al-'Araf

Surah Al-'Araf, 7:47 –

أَصْحَابُ الْأَعْرَافِ

Shakir: the Dwellers of the Most Elevated Places,

Irving: The Companions on the Heights,

Saffarzadeh: the men on the Heights (of The Barrier),

Qara'i: the occupants of the Elevations,

Pickthall: the dwellers on the Heights,

Yusuf Ali: The men on the Heights;

Arberry: the dwellers on the Battlements.

Analysis:

Culturally, As-hab al- a'raf is a certain group of people which will be kept on the barrier between hell and heaven waiting for God's judgment¹⁹. Therefore, it seems more appropriate to translate it as the name of a group, rather than translating the words itself so as to have the reader notice them instead of passing by without noticing what happens to that group.

As'hab Al-Fil

Surah Al-Fil, 105: 1 -

أَصْحَابِ الْفِيلِ

Shakir: the Possessors of the Elephant;

Irving, Saffarzadeh, and Pickthall: the owners of the Elephant.

Arberry, and Qara'i: the Men of the Elephant.

Sarwar: the people of the elephant,

Yusuf Ali: the Companions of the Elephant.

Analysis:

As-hab al-Fil is an army commanded by Abraha who marched towards Mecca to destroy the Kabbah in the year when the Messenger of Islam(S) was born. The army rode elephants, hence the name As-hab al-Fil, which literally means the army with elephants²⁰. This is a title exclusively given to the Army of Abraha, therefore, transliterating the title (As-hab al-Fil) is not wrong. However, if one insists on translating, a clear translation such as 'the army which rode Elephants' or 'The Riders of Elephants' must be used. According to what we have mentioned, none of the aforementioned translations seem appropriate because they are literal translations. Some are even wrong, although they may be accepted considering some justifications. Some translators have made the same mistake with (أَصْحَابَ السَّبْتِ): the Violators of the Sabbath.

As-hab As-Sabat

Surah An-Nisa', 4:47 –

أَصْحَابَ السَّبْتِ

Irving: the masters of the Sabbath;

Qara'i, Sarwar: the People of the Sabbath;

Arberry: Sabbath men.

As-hab al- Qubur

Surah Al-Mumtahana 60:13 –

أَصْحَابِ الْقُبُورِ

Shakir: those in tombs,

Irving, Arberry: the inhabitants of tombs;

Saffarzadeh, Yusuf Ali, Pickthall: those buried in the graves;

Qara'i: the occupants of the graves.

Analysis:

As-hab al- Qubur refers to the dead, as if they are companions of the grave. The translation must convey the meaning of dead people in the grave. It seems that some of the translations that are literal could have been improved to prevent reader confusion, which both betrays readers of the target language and the source text, because the meaning has been neglected.

Sadr

Sadr – صدر

(صدر) is the plural form of (صدر), literally meaning breast. The Qur'an uses this word in two ways, none of which actually means breast. Some translators have translated it literally and confused the readers. We shall study the equivalent that translators have chosen and analyse them:

Surah Faatir, 35:38 –

إِنَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِذَاتِ الصُّدُورِ

Shakir, Qara'i, Pickthall, Arberry: Surely Allah knows what is in the breasts,

Irving: God is Aware of what is on your minds;

Saffarzadeh, Sarwar, Yusuf Ali: Allah is the Knower of The secrets of the hearts.

Analysis:

The translators have chosen to use breasts, minds, or hearts to translate **ʿudur**. A simple search in the verses of the Qur'an and reliable exegeses shows that the meaning of (**ʿadr**) in the Qur'an is not mind or breast, but the spiritual heart or soul which has been placed within the breast according to the Qur'an. This soul is what gains good and bad qualities, although it is not visible²¹.

The translation of **ʿadr** changes when collocated with (Yashrah, literally means expanding) and (Yadhiq, literally means reducing) and their roots, as we shall see next.

Surah Al-An'am, 6: 125 –

فَمَنْ يَرِدِ اللَّهُ أَنْ يَهْدِيَهُ يَشْرَحْ صَدْرَهُ لِلْإِسْلَامِ وَمَنْ يُرِدْ أَنْ يُضِلَّهُ يَجْعَلْ صَدْرَهُ ضَيِّقًا حَرَجًا كَأَنَّمَا يَصْعَدُ فِي السَّمَاءِ
كَذَلِكَ يَجْعَلُ اللَّهُ الرِّجْسَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ لَا يُؤْمِنُونَ

Translations:

Shakir: Therefore, for whomsoever Allah intends that He would guide him right, He expands his breast for Islam And for whomsoever He intends that He should cause him err, He makes his breast straight and narrow as though he were ascending upwards.

Irving: God lays anyone's breast open to Islam whom He wants to guide, while He makes the breast of anyone He wants to be led astray seem cramped, tight, just as if he were climbing up to Heaven. Thus, God places a blight on those who do not believe.

Saffarzadeh: And whomsoever Allah Wills to guide, Expands his breast for Islam, and Whomsoever He Wills to be left in his Error, He makes his breast closed And narrow as if he is climbing up to the very sky. Thus, Allah puts an Igominious Chastisement on those who refuse to believe;

Qara'i: Whomever Allah desires to guide, He opens his breast to Islam, and whomever He desires to lead astray, He makes his breast narrow and straitened as if he were climbing to a height. Thus, does Allah lay] spiritual [defilement on those who do not have faith.

Pickthall: ... He expanded his bosom unto the Surrender, and whomsoever it is His Will to send astray,

He makes his bosom close and narrow as if he were engaged in sheer ascent.

Sarwar: God will open the hearts of whomever He wants to guide to Islam, but He will tighten the chest of one whom He has led astray, as though he was climbing high up into the sky. Thus, God places wickedness on those who do not accept the faith;

Yusuf Ali: Those whom Allah willeth to guide, – – He openeth their breast to Islam; those whom He willeth to leave straying, – – He maketh their breast close and constricted, as if they had to climb up to the skies: thus, doth Allah lay abomination on those who refuse to believe.

Arberry: Whomsoever God desires to guide, He expands his breast to Islam whomsoever He desires to lead astray, He makes his breast narrow, tight as if he were climbing to heaven) ascending upwards (So God lays abomination upon those who believe not).

Analysis:

The aforementioned translations are literal translations. The clarity of these translations can be improved. The word **ṣadr** collocates with **Yashrah** and **Yadhiq** and obtains new meanings, such as, increasing capacity and reducing capacity. The same applies to 94: 1; 15:97.

Therefore, we suggested the following translation:

...so whomever God wills to guide (due to his good deed and good intentions), He increases His capacity to (embrace) Islam, but whomever He wills to lead astray (due to his evil intentions and bad deeds), He reduces his capacity (so he cannot exercise patience in God's path) as if he ascends upwards to the sky. Thus, God brings spiritual impurity to those who abandon belief²².

Surah Al-'Araf, 7:2 –

كِتَابٌ أَنْزَلْنَا إِلَيْكَ فَلَا يَكُنْ فِي صَدْرِكَ حَرَجٌ مِنْهُ لِتُنَذِرَ بِهِ

Translation:

Shakir: A Book revealed to you so let there be no straitness in your breast on account of it

Irving: A Book has been sent down to you, so do not let your breast feel it is under any constraint)

Saffarzadeh: This] Holy [Book Is sent down to you, so do not let your Heart be depressed (by problems Related to your Mission).

Qara'i: This is [a Book that has been sent down to you so let there be no disquiet in your heart on its account.

Pickthall: It is (a Scripture that is revealed unto thee (Muhammad) so let there be no heaviness in thy heart therefrom.

Sarwar: A book has been revealed to you, Muhammad. You should not hesitate to convey its warning

Yusuf Ali: A Book revealed unto thee, – – So let thy heart be oppressed no more by any difficulty on that account

Arberry: A Book sent down to thee so let there be no impediment in thy breast because of it.

Analysis:

In this verse, (سَٰدِرٌ) means spiritual heart.

In (فِي صَدْرِكَ حَرَجٌ) it means doubt of or disquiet in the heart²³. The equivalent used by some translators such as Qara'i seems more appropriate than those who used (breast) and literally translated it. Therefore, we suggest the following translation:

(It is) the book which has been sent down to you, so your heart should not be filled with disquiet concerning it (if you see people disregard it).²⁴

Solution For Translating The Words Of The Qur'an

There are three types of words in the Qur'an:

Words which have equivalents in the target language: We use the equivalents that exist.

Words which are ambiguous and have various meanings, such as *sadr*, *Ahl*, and etc.: These words must be translated according to their meaning in the text and literal translation must be avoided. However, many the translators avoided to used proper equivalents and use the literal meaning instead.

Words with no equivalent because they are exclusively Qur'anic words, such as *Qisas*, *Ka'bah*, *Qiblah*, and *taqwa*. A translator must not create an equivalent for them. These words must be transliterated, since they are exclusive to the Qur'an and have been extracted from Qur'anic culture.

Expressions And Problematic Phrases

This group is the most troublesome and challenging phrases of the Qur'an for translators. We have chosen to study phrases because they are like expressions and proverbs, the literal meanings are usually completely meaningless because of culture and syntax differences between the source and target language.

Antum Sharr Makana

أَنْتُمْ شَرُّ مَكَانًا

In Surah Yusuf, 12:77²⁵

According to commentaries, the meaning of this phrase is: “you are the worst”²⁶.

Let’s see how translators have dealt with it.

Translations:

Qara’i: He said, " You are in a worse state!

Shakir: He (simply) said (to himself):" Ye are the worse situated;

Irving: He said:" You are in a worse plight!

Saffarzadeh: You are in the worst condition,

Pickthall: Ye are in worse case

Sarwar: You are in a worse position.

Yusuf Ali: Ye are the worse situated

Arberry: You are in a worse case.

Analysis:

مَكَانًا has not been literally mentioned in the commentaries and the commentators translated شَرُّ مَكَانًا as a phrase (i.e. The worse). They have refrained from translating each word of the phrase literally. However, the translators have preferred the literal translation of this expression using various words such as state, plight, condition, situated, position, and case. Although these translations are not incorrect, but they still have room for improvement.

Qal Ya 'Asafa

قَالَ يَا أَصْفَى

In Surah Yusuf, 12:84²⁷

In his valuable book (al- Mufradat), Raghib al- Isfahani states that اَصْف means grief that comes along

with rage. Sometimes it can mean grief or rage, separately. The reality of **أسف** means desire for taking revenge. When confronted with someone stronger, one is left with the regret of not being able to take revenge, but when confronted with someone weaker, one's rage can erupt²⁸. The Qur'an says:

فَلَمَّا آسَفُونَا انْتَقَمْنَا مِنْهُمْ

it means, ***"We took revenge when they made us wrathful"*** (43:55)

Translations:

Shakir: He said: O my sorrow for Yusuf!

Irving: How upset I feel over Joseph!

Saffarzadeh: Alas! My grief is great for Yusuf!

Qara'i: Alas for Joseph!"

Pickthall: Alas, my grief for Joseph!

Sarwar: Alas, Joseph is lost!"

Yusuf Ali: How great is my grief for Joseph

Arberry: Ah, woe is me for Joseph!

Analysis:

Commentaries and research show that this phrase displays Jacob's deep sympathy for Joseph and how he was overcome with grief. Jacob lost his sight because of how much he cried for Joseph²⁹. Therefore, some of the aforementioned translations, including Arberry, Sarwar, and others, although correct, can still be improved.

Abyadhdhat A'ynah Min Al-Huzn

ابْيَضَّتْ عَيْنَاهُ مِنَ الْحُزَنِ

In Surah Yusuf, 12:84³⁰

This expression means he grieved so much that he lost sight out and his eyes turned white³¹.

Let's see how the translators dealt with this expression.

Translations:

Shakir: his eyes became white on account of the grief.

Irving: Both his eyes clouded over from sadness.

Qara'i: His eyes had turned white with grief.

Pickthall: And his eyes were whitened with the sorrow.

Sarwar: Alas, Joseph is lost!" He wept continuously in his grief.

Yusuf Ali: And his eyes became white with sorrow.

Arberry: And his eyes turned white because of the sorrow.

Analysis:

Instead of conveying the message of the expression, the translators preferred to write the literal meaning of **أَبْيَضَتْ عَيْنَاهُ**. This leaves the readers in doubt, although a little bit of pondering by the reader reveals that any eye that turns white, is indeed blind.

Tadh-hab Ryhukum

تَذْهَبَ رِيحُكُمْ

In Surah Al-Anfal, 8:46³²

رِيحٌ literally means smell or wind, but in this phrase the literal meaning is not meant. Most classic commentators have stated the meaning of this phrase to be power and position³³.

Therefore, the expression (**تَذْهَبَ رِيحُكُمْ**) means you lose your unity, power, and strength.

We shall study the translations to see how the translators did with this phrase.

Translations:

Shakir: And obey Allah and His Messenger and do not quarrel for then you will be weak in hearts and your power will depart.

Irving: Obey God and His messenger and do not argue with one another, so that you will falter and lose your courage.

Saffarzadeh: And obey Allah and Allah's Messenger and do not quarrel with One another, lest you may

get Weak-hearted and your spiritual power May go away.

Qara'i: And obey Allah and His Apostle, and do not dispute, or you will lose heart and your power will be gone.

Pickthall: And obey Allah and His messenger, and dispute not one with another lest ye falter and your strength depart from you; but be steadfast!

Sarwar: Obey God and His Messenger. Do not quarrel with each other lest you fail or lose honour.

Yusuf Ali And obey Allah and His Messenger. And fall into no disputes, lest ye lose heart and your power depart.

Arberry: And obey God, and His Messenger, and do not quarrel together, and so lose heart, and your power depart.

Analysis:

A literal translation of this expression makes no sense at all. All translators have provided the meaning of the expression; therefore, they have all partially conveyed the message correctly.

Dayiq Bih Sadruk

ضَائِقٌ بِهِ صَدْرُكَ

In Surah Hud, 11:12³⁴

According to Majma' al-bayan ضَائِقٌ comes along with صَدْرٌ when someone is bored and under pressure³⁵.

Shakir: Then, it may be that you will give up part of what is revealed to you and your breast will become straitened by it.

Irving: Perhaps you are abandoning something that has been inspired in you, and your breast is feeling cramped because of it.

Saffarzadeh: So perhaps you O, Messenger be inclined to give up a part of what is Revealed to you and your heart Becomes straitened.

Qara'i: Look out lest you should disregard aught of what has been revealed to you, and be upset.

Pickthall: A likely thing, that thou wouldst forsake aught of that which hath been revealed unto thee, and that thy breast should be straitened for it.

Sarwar: Perhaps you, Muhammad, may by chance leave untold a part of that which is revealed to you and feel grieved.

Yusuf Ali: Perchance thou mayest feel the inclination (to give up a part of what is revealed unto thee, and thy heart feeleth straitened.

Arberry: Perchance thou art leaving part of what is revealed to thee, and thy breast is straitened by it.

Abtigha' Wajh Allah

اِبْتِغَاءَ وَجْهِ اللَّهِ

In Surah al-Baqara, 2:272³⁶

وَجْهِ has different meanings, including face, but in the verse above it means pleasure of God. The verse says that some people only spend in order to gain God's pleasure³⁷. We shall study the translations to see how this phrase in this verse has been translated:

Translations:

Shakir: And whatever good thing you spend, it is to your own good and you do not spend but to seek Allah's pleasure.

Irving: He wishes to. Any tax money you may spend is for your own good and whatever you spend is only through a craving to see God's face.

Saffarzadeh: And whatever good things you spend in charity it shall be for your own souls; but do not spend in Charity except for seeking the Pleasure of Allah.

Qara'i: And whatever wealth you spend, it is for your own benefit, as you do not spend but to seek Allah's pleasure.

Pickthall: And whatsoever good thing ye spend, it is for yourselves, when ye spend not save in search of Allah's Countenance.

Sarwar: Whatever you spend for the cause of God is for your own good, provided you do not spend anything but to please God.

Yusuf Ali: Whatever of good ye give benefits your own souls, and ye shall only do so seeking the "Face" of Allah.

Arberry: And whatever good you expend is for yourselves for then you are expending, being desirous only of God's Face.

Analysis:

We see that some of the translators such as Pickthall, Arberry, Yusuf Ali and Irving ignore the meaning of the phrase and choose the literal meaning instead. Therefore, an element of ambiguity exists in their translations.

Darba Fi 'l-Ard

ضَرْباً فِي الْأَرْضِ

In Surah al-Baqara, 2:273³⁸

ضَرْبٌ literally means hitting and the literal meaning of the phrase is hitting the earth, but the literal meaning of this phrase is not intended in this verse. ضَرْباً فِي الْأَرْضِ here means traveling, in English it would be something like 'hitting the road'. Those who do not have adequate skills in Arabic may mistakenly use the literal translation instead.

Translations:

Shakir: Alms are (for the poor who are confined in the Way of Allah they cannot go about in the land.

Irving: Take care of the poor who, being totally absorbed in working for God's cause, cannot manage to travel.

Saffarzadeh: Charity is for those poor who are besieged in the Path of Allah and Thereby prevented from travelling.

Qara'i: The charities are [for the poor who are straitened in the way of Allah, not capable of moving about in the land for trade.

Pickthall: Alms are (for the poor who are straitened for the cause of Allah, who cannot travel in the land) for trade.

Sarwar: If the recipients of charity are (the poor whose poverty, because of their striving for the cause of God, has become an obstacle for them, and who do not have the ability to travel in the land.

Yusuf Ali: Charity is for those in need, who, in Allah's cause are restricted (from travel), and cannot move about in the land.

Arberry: freewill offerings being for the poor who are restrained in the Way of God, and are unable to journey in the land.

Analysis:

All translators, even those who are usually inclined to use literal translations, have instead translated the meaning of the phrase.

Yakulun Ar-Riba

يَأْكُلُونَ الرِّبَا

In Surah al-Baqara, 2:275³⁹

يَأْكُلُونَ means they eat and الرِّبَا means usury. It's not common to 'eat usury' in English, rather, usury is 'exercise'; We suggest that the literal meaning of the phrase should be avoided and the English equivalent used instead.

Translations:

Shakir: Those who swallow down usury cannot arise except as one whom Shaitan has prostrated by his touch does rise.

Irving: Those who live off the interest on loans will never stand up, except in the way those whom Satan knocks down with a fit rise up again.

Saffarzadeh: Those who swallow usury will not stand] On the Day of Resurrection [except Like the standing of a person touched by Satan.

Qara'i: Those who exact usury will not stand but like one deranged by the Devil's touch.

Pickthall: Those who swallow usury cannot rise up save as he arises whom the devil hath prostrated by (his) touch.

Sarwar: Those who take unlawful interest will stand before God on the Day of Judgment as those who suffer from a mental imbalance.

Yusuf Ali: Those who devour usury will not stand except as stand one whom the Satan by his touch hath driven to madness.

Arberry: Those who devour usury shall not rise again except as he rises, whom Satan of the touch prostrates.

Analysis:

Some translators such as Shakir, Saffarzadeh, Pickthall, Yusuf Ali, and Arberry used the word 'swallow' instead of the proper collocation for usury. In English, it is the interest obtained through usury that is 'consumed' or 'eaten' not the usury itself, therefore, these translations have ambiguity.

Subhanah 'An Yakun La Walad

سُبْحَانَهُ أَنْ يَكُونَ لَهُ وَلَدٌ

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:171⁴⁰

'Walad' means child. This verse says that God is very glorious, so it is beyond Him to have a child.

Translations:

Shakir: it is better for you Allah is only One God Far be it from His glory that He should have a son.

Irving: God is only One God; glory be to Him, beyond His having any son!

Qara'i: That is better for you. Allah is but the One God. He is far too immaculate to have any son.

Saffarzadeh: Allah is The One and the only God; He is Exalted above having a son] as the disbelievers claim.

Pickthall: say not three it removed from His Transcendent Majesty that He should have a son.

Sarwar: There is only One God. He is too glorious to give birth to a son.

Yusuf Ali: Allah is One God. Glory be to Him: far exalted is He above having a son.

Arberry: God is only One God Glory be to Him that He should have a son!

Analysis:

All the translators understood the message of the phrase but they did not use a clearer way to convey the message. This verse says, 'God is too glorious to have a child.' Among the translators, Ali Quli Qara'i has used a better structure to convey such a meaning. Although other translators have not made a mistake, but there is room for improvement.

Turawid Fataha 'An Nafsihi; Qad Shaghafaha Hubban; Dalal Mubin

تُرَاوِدُ فَتَاهَا عَنْ نَفْسِهِ

قَدْ شَغَفَهَا حُبًّا

ضَلَالٍ مُّبِينٍ

The phrases above are all in verse 12:30⁴¹, but we will discuss them separately:

Translations:

Shakir: And women in the city said: The chief's wife seeks her slave to yield himself (to her). Surely, he has affected her deeply with (his) love. Most surely, we see her in manifest error.

Irving: Some women in the city said: " The official's wife wants to seduce her houseboy. He's set her madly in love! We see she has gone clear astray."

Saffarzadeh: And women in the city said: " The wife of Aziz is seeking from her slave-boy an Evil deed. Indeed, he has affected her Heart deeply with love; verily, we behold her in an obvious error."

Qara'i: Some of the townswomen said, " The chieftain's wife has solicited her slave boy! He has captivated her love. Indeed, we see her to be in manifest error."

Pickthall: And women in the city said: The ruler's wife is asking of her slave-boy an ill- deed. Indeed, he has smitten her to the heart with love. We behold her in plain aberration.

Sarwar: Some of the women in the town started to gossip saying, " The King's wife has tried to seduce her servant and has fallen madly in love with him. We think that she is in manifest error".

Yusuf Ali: Ladies said in the City: " The wife of the (great) Aziz is seeking to seduce her slave. Truly hath he inspired her with violent love: we see she is evidently going astray."

Arberry: Certain women that were in the city said, The Governor's wife has been soliciting her page he smote her heart with love we see her in manifest error.

Analysis:

Commentaries of the Qur'an define these phrases as such:

تُرَاوِدُ فَتَاهَا عَنْ نَفْسِهِ

The wife of the governor of Egypt invited her young servant to herself in order to enjoy him and have intercourse with him.

قَدْ شَغَفَهَا حُبًّا

She felt a burning and profound love for him.

ضَلَالٍ مُبِينٍ

Glaring error.

The first phrase needs the most attention, because it creates the greatest challenge for those who are not skilful in Arabic, which is why some translators have produced strange translations. The literal meanings of the phrase is the following:

تُرَاوِدُ: she desires or insistently wants intercourse, etc.

فَتَاها: her young servant

عَنْ: from

نَفْسِهِ: himself

The literal translations of the last two words: (عَنْ نَفْسِهِ) makes the phrase ambiguous for the translators. Hence, translators like Shakir could have produced better results if they hadn't translated the phrase literally. The rest of the translators preferred to write the meaning of the phrase and avoid literal translating.

The third phrase ضَلَالٍ مُبِينٍ, if we accept ضَلَالٍ means error, it seems that the best collocation for error is: glaring, i.e., the error which is very evident.

'Amalu 'Ala Mekanatikum

اعْمَلُوا عَلَىٰ مَكَانَتِكُمْ

In Surah Az-Zumar, 39:39⁴²

This phrase is the reply of some of God's messengers to their enemies when they were despaired that they will not give up corruption. The messenger warns his enemy that if they want to disobey and oppose, they can do their best according to their position, power and facility and he will do his best to perform his duty and his enemy will soon come to know the result.

Translations:

Shakir: Say: O my people! Work in your place, surely, I am a worker so you will come to know.

Irving: Say:" My people, act according to your situation. I am so acting, and you shall know.

Saffarzadeh: Say O, Messenger!" O, my people! Exercise your power against me as much as you can; and I too will act According to my Mission, soon you will know.

Qara'i: Say," O my people! Act according to your ability. I too am acting. Soon you will know.

Pickthall: Say: O my people! Act in your manner. Lo! I (too) am acting. Thus, ye will come to know.

Sarwar: Say," My people, act as you wish. I shall do as I like and you will soon know.

Yusuf Ali Say:" O my People! Do whatever ye can: I will do my part: but soon will ye know

Arberry: Say: My people, act according to your station; I am acting and soon you will know)

Analysis:

We see that according to the meaning of the phrase some of the translators such as Shakir and Pickthall were not successful to convey the meaning and some of them such as Sarwar, Qara'i and Saffarzadeh has done it better. And the meaning of the phrase can be understood from their translations.

Bu'dan

بُعْدًا

In Surah Hud, 11:95^{[43](#)}

بُعْدًا even though has been used in the form of statement, it is a prayer, through which God curse the wrongdoers saying, ‘ May wrongdoers be away (from God’s mercy)’^{[44](#)}.

Translations:

Shakir: As though they had never dwelt in them now surely perdition overtook Madyan as had perished Samood.

Irving: just as if they had never prospered there. Was it not away with Midian, just as Thamud was also sent away?

Saffarzadeh: It seemed as if they had not lived there any time; so away with the people of Madyan as away with the Thamud!

Qara'i: as if they had never lived there. Look! Away with Midian! Just as Thamoud was done away with!

Pickthall: As though they had not dwelt there. A far removal for Midian, even as Thamud had been removed afar!

Sarwar: as though they had never existed. How far from) the mercy of God (had the people of Midian gone, just as those of Thamud?

Yusuf Ali: As if they had never dwelt and flourished there! So away with Madyan as were Thamud!

Arberry: as if they had never dwelt there so away with Midian, even as Thamood was done away.

Analysis:

It seems that some translators such as Shakir translated the phrase as a statement and he neglected its meaning which is a prayer and some else such as Irving did not grasp the meaning nor structure and his translation cannot have considered as a correct one but some such as Qara'i seems successful in their translations.

Qala Rabbi Shrahli Sadri

قَالَ رَبِّ اشْرَحْ لِي صَدْرِي

In Surah Ta Ha, 20:25

The literal translations of this phrase: اشْرَحْ: expand لي: for me صَدْرِي: my breast. What it means? It seems that its literal meaning seems meaningless and irrelevant for the English readers but this is the prayer of Moses to God who pray to him it means "Increase my capacity in order to shoulder the great responsibility of prophet hood."

Translations:

Shakir: He said: O my Lord! Expand my breast for me.

Irving: He said:" My Lord, ease my breast for me!

Saffarzadeh: Mussa said:" O, my Creator and Nurturer! Please expand the power of insight, Planning and endurance to my heart and my mind.

Qara'i: He said," My Lord! Open my breast for me.

Pickthall: Moses said: My Lord! relieve my mind.

Sarwar: Moses said," Lord, grant me courage.

Yusuf Ali: Moses said: " O my Lord! expand me breast.

Arberry: Lord, open my breast, said Moses.

Analysis:

According to what we explained, only Saffarzadeh tried to convey the meaning of the phrase and other translators translated it literally so the meaning seems ambiguous and irrelevant to the readers.

Kay Taqarra 'Aynuha

كَي تَقَرَّ عَيْنُهَا

In Surah Ta Ha, 20:40⁴⁵ & Surah Al-Qasas 28: 13⁴⁶

This phrase literally means: كَي: in order that تَقَرَّ: become bright. عَيْنُهَا: her eye. When some somebody get happy his/her eyes become bright and flash in happiness. This phrase says that (God returned Moses to his mother) in order that she become delightful. Thus, God brought joy to her.

Thus, the literal meaning of this verse is not completely clear to the readers in English contrary to the readers in Persian which the literal meanings is same with its meaning.

Translations of 28: 13 –

Shakir: So We gave him back to his mother that her eye might be refreshed, and that she might not grieve.

Irving: Thus, We restored him to his mother so he might comfort her and she would not feel so sad.

Saffarzadeh: So We returned him back to his mother, to be the joy of her eyes; and that she should know that Allah's Promise is true.

Qara'i: Thus, We restored him to his mother so that she might be comforted and not grieve, and that she might know that Allah's promise is true.

Pickthall: So We restored him to his mother that she might be comforted and not grieve, and that she might know that the promise of Allah is true.

Sarwar: Thus, did We return Moses to his mother that We would delight her eyes, relieve her sorrows.

Yusuf Ali: Thus, did We restore him to his mother, that her eye might be comforted, that she might not grieve.

Arberry: So We returned him to his mother that she might be comforted and not sorrow.

Analysis:

All the translators avoided to give a literal translation, and they tried to convey the meaning even though their translations could have been clearer if they had fully avoided the literal translation.

Dhaqqat 'Alayhim Al-Ardh Bima Rahubat; Dhaqqat 'Alayhim 'Anfusuhum

ضَاقَتْ عَلَيْهِمُ الْأَرْضُ بِمَا رَحُبَتْ - ضَاقَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ أَنْفُسُهُمْ

In Surah At-Tawbah, 9: 118⁴⁷

The literal translations of the words: حَتَّى: until ضَاقَتْ: became narrow, strait, عَلَيْهِمْ: upon them الْأَرْضُ: the earth: with all its expanse, spaciousness. This phrase means that they were so sorrowful so the spacious earth seems narrow as Sarwar translated Grief made them feel as though there was no place in the whole vast earth to hide them or in their souls to conceal their sorrow

Translations:

Shakir: And to the three who were left behind, until the earth became strait to them notwithstanding its spaciousness and their souls were also straitened to them; and they knew it for certain that there was no refuge from Allah but in Him.

Irving: As for the three who were left behind, until the earth seemed too cramped for them, spacious though it is, and even their souls seemed to strangle them and they thought there would be no refuge from God except through Himself.

Saffarzadeh: And also Allah turned in Mercy to The three of them who were left behind until when the earth, despite all its vastness became strait for them, and their own souls were straitened for them and they thought there was no Shelter against Allah's Wrath.

Qara'i: and to the three who were left behind. When the earth became narrow for them with (all) its expanse, and their own souls weighed heavily on them, and they knew that there was no refuge from Allah except in Him.

Pickthall: And to the three also did He turn in mercy who were left behind, when the earth, vast as it is, was straitened for them, and their own souls were straitened for them till they bethought them that there is no refuge from Allah save toward Him.

Sarwar: God also forgave the three people who lagged behind. Grief made them feel as though there was no place in the whole vast earth to hide them or in their souls to conceal their sorrow. They began to believe that no one could save them from (the wrath of God) except He Himself.

Yusuf Ali: He turned in mercy also (to the three who were left behind;) they felt guilty (to such a degree that the earth seemed constrained to them, for all its spaciousness, and their) very (souls seemed straitened to them, – and they perceived that there is no fleeing from Allah) and no refuge (but to Himself).

Arberry: And to the three who were left behind, until, when the earth became strait for them, for all its breadth, and their souls became strait for them, and they thought that there was no shelter from God except in Him.

Analysis:

The translations of Yusuf Ali and Sarwar are understandable and convey the meanings of the phrase because of their analysis but other translators translated literally and there is ambiguity in their literal translations in English and the meaning is not conveyed clearly.

Bima Qaddamat 'Aydyhim

بِمَا قَدَّمَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ

In Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:95, and Surah Al-Jumu'a, 62:7[48](#)

This phrase has also been used in many other verses[49](#).

The literal translation of this phrase is: بِمَا: because of what, قَدَّمَتْ: sent before. أَيْدِيهِمْ: their hands the whole phrase says because of what their hands sent ahead. We see that this phrase is ambiguous for the readers in English.

The meaning of this phrase is that what they done or committed. In general, a deed is done or a sin is committed with hands, so the deeds have been attributed to the hands instead of person. This verse says that the Jews will not long for death because of the evil deeds they have committed and sent ahead for their hereafter and they know that when they die, they will meet the outcome of their evil deeds.

Translations:

Shakir: And they will never invoke it on account of what their hands have sent before and Allah knows the unjust. Irving: They will never long for it because of what their hands have already prepared. God is Aware of wrongdoers!

Saffarzadeh: But they will never long for death, Because of what their hands have sent before them to the other world and Allah is Well-Aware of the deeds and Intentions of the wrongdoers.

Qara'i: But they will not long for it ever because of what their hands have sent ahead, and Allah knows

best the wrongdoers.

Pickthall: But they will never long for it, because of that which their own hands have sent before them. Allah is aware of evil-doers.

Sarwar: But they can never have a longing for death because of what they have done. God knows the unjust well

Yusuf Ali: But they will never seek for death, on account of the (sins) which their hands have sent on before them. And Allah is well-acquainted with the wrong-doers.

Arberry: But they will never long for it, because of that their hands have forwarded God knows the evildoers.

Analysis:

Some of the translators such as Shakir, Qara'i, Pickthall, and Arberry have translated the phrase literally and some of them such as Sarwar has wrote the meaning and some of them such as Yusuf Ali has tried to convey the meaning with adding Analysis to the literal translations of the words. However, what we can say is that literal translation of this phrase cannot completely convey the meaning and intention of the phrase.

Wa Akhfid Janahak

وَ اخْفِضْ جَنَاحَكَ

In Surah Ash-Shu'ara', 26:215[50](#)

Literally this phrase means: اخْفِضْ: lower. جَنَاحَكَ: your wings. This is act like the act of a hen which lower its wings and mercifully gather and protect its young chicken. thus, God commanded His Messenger to mercifully treat with believers who follow him.

Translations:

Shakir: And be kind to him who follows you of the believers.

Irving: lower your protecting wing over any believers who may follow you.

Saffarzadeh: And be humble to the believers who follow you.

Qara'i: and lower your wing to the faithful.

Pickthall: and lower thy wing) in tenderness (for the believers).

Sarwar: Be kind to the believers.

Yusuf Ali lower thy wing (in gentleness) to the believers.

Arberry: and lower thy wing unto the believers.

Analysis:

Qara'i and Arberry translated the phrase literally and the other translations has tried to write the meaning of the phrase. Those who translate it literally should take into consideration that this phrase is an Arabic phrase according to Arab culture, so the readers in English may not receive the message without analysis.

Fata'ala 'Amma Yushrikun

فَتَعَالَىٰ عَمَّا يُشْرِكُونَ

In Surah Al-Mu'minun, 23:92[51](#)

This says that God is above having any partners that they ascribe to Him in other words God is too exalted to have partners which they ascribe to Him.

Translations:

Shakir: The Knower of the unseen and the seen, so may He be exalted above what they associate (with Him).

Irving: Knower of the Unseen and the Visible: Exalted is He over anything they may associate with Him.

Saffarzadeh: Allah is the Knower of the Unseen and The Visible and He is above the idea of having partners.

Qara'i: The Knower of the sensible and the Unseen, He is above having any partners that they ascribe to Him.

Pickthall: Knower of the Invisible and the Visible! And Exalted be He over all that they ascribe as partners unto Him (!).

Sarwar: He has the knowledge of all seen and unseen things. He is too exalted to be considered equal to anything else.

Yusuf Ali: He knows what is hidden and what is open: too high is He for the partners they attribute to Him!

Arberry: who has knowledge of the Unseen and the Visible; high exalted be He, above that they associate!

Analysis:

This phrase is a statement, but the translation of Shakir is not in the form of statement. Saffarzadeh added "idea" to his translation while this verse does not discuss about idea of having partner rather it says He is too exalted to have a partner, so they cannot ascribe partner to Him. Sarwar omitted the subject i.e. (they) in his translation and it seems the translation of Qara'i is clearer than the other translations and is more successful in conveying the meaning.

- [1.](#) Tabataba'i 1417 A.H., 19/20
- [2.](#) Raghīb Isfahani 1412 A.H.
- [3.](#) See: Ibn Manzūr 1414, Mustafaw 1360 Sh, Raghīb Isfahani 1412 A.H, Qurashshi 1371 Sh
- [4.](#) See Tabataba'i 1417A.H., Tusi, Al-Tibyan fi tafsir al-Qur'an 1405 A.H, Turayhi 1375 Sh, M. Zamakhshari, Al-Kashshaf 'an haqa'iq ghawamidh al-tanzil 1407 A.H, F.-D. Razi, Mafatih al-ghayb 1420 A.H, F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh.
- [5.](#) a.S. Tabataba'i 1417 A.H..
- [6.](#) See: Mustafaw 1360 Sh, 1:168, Qurashshi 1371 Sh, Turayhi 1375 Sh, Ibn Manzūr 1414, Farahidi 1410 AH, Raghīb Isfahani 1412 A.H.
- [7.](#) See: Tusi, Al-Tibyan fi tafsir al-Qur'an 1405 A.H, Tabataba'i 1417A.H., F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh, Qummi 1367 Sh.
- [8.](#) See: F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh, 7:64
- [9.](#) See: Suyuti 1404 A.H.
- [10.](#) See: Qurashshi 1371 Sh, Qummi 1367 Sh.
- [11.](#) See: Ibn Manzūr 1414, Mustafaw 1360 Sh, Qummi 1367 Sh, Raghīb Isfahani 1412 A.H, Qurashshi 1371 Sh.
- [12.](#) : The translation of the verses related to the story of Moses ('a) are provided below in order to shed light on the process of finding a good equivalent for it:

We recite to you from the account of Musa and Fir'awn with truth for people who believe (28:3)

Surely, Fir'awn exalted himself in the land and made its people into parties, weakening one party from among them; he slaughtered their sons and let their women live; surely, he was one of the mischiefmakers (28:4)

And We desired to bestow a favor upon those who were deemed weak in the land, and to make them the Imams, and to make them the heirs (28:5)

And to grant them power in the land, and to make Fir'awn and Haman and their hosts see from them what they feared (28:6)

And We revealed to Musa's mothers, saying: Give him suck, then when you fear for him, cast him into the river and do not fear nor grieve; surely, We will bring him back to you and make him one of the messengers (28:7)

And Fir'awn's family took him up that he might be an enemy and a grief for them; surely, Fir'awn and Haman and their hosts were wrongdoers (28:8)

And Fir'awn's wife said: A refreshment of the eye to me and to you; do not slay him; maybe he will be useful to us, or we may take him for a son; and they did not perceive (28:9)

And the heart of Musa's mother was free (from anxiety) she would have almost disclosed it had We not strengthened her heart so, that she might be of the believers (28:10)

And she said to his sister: Follow him up. So, she watched him from a distance while they did not perceive (28:11)

And We ordained that he refused to suck any foster mother before, so, she said: Shall I point out to you the people of a house who will take care of him for you, and they will be benevolent to him? (28:12)

So, We gave him back to his mother that her eye might be refreshed, and that she might no grieve, and that she might know that the promise of Allah is true, but most of them do not know (28:13)

And when he attained his maturity and became full grown, We granted him wisdom and knowledge; and thus, do We

reward those who do good (to others) (28:14)

And he went into the city at a time of unvigilance on the part of its people, so, he found therein two men fighting, one being of his party and the other of his foes, and he who was of his party cried out to him for help against him who was of his enemies, so, Musa struck him with his fist and killed him. He said: This is on account of the Shaitan's doing; surely, he is an enemy, openly leading astray (28:15)

He said: My Lord! surely, I have done harm to myself, so, do Thou protect me. So, He protected him; surely, He is the Forgiving, the Merciful (28:16)

He said: My Lord! because Thou hast bestowed a favor on me, I shall never be a backer of the guilty (28:17)

And he was in the city, earing, awaiting, when lo! he who had asked his assistance the day before was crying out to him for aid. Musa said to him: You are most surely, one erring manifestly (28:18)

So, when he desired to seize him who was an enemy to them both, he said: O Musa! do you intend to kill me as you killed a person yesterday? You desire nothing but that you should be a tyrant in the land, and you do not desire to be of those who act aright (28:19)

And a man came running from the remotest part of the city. He said: O Musa! surely, the chiefs are consulting together to slay you, therefore depart (at once); surely, I am of those who wish well to you (28:20)

So, he went forth therefrom, fearing, awaiting, (and) he said: My Lord! deliver me from the unjust people (28:21)

And when he turned his face towards Madyan, he said: Maybe my Lord will guide me in the right path (28:22)

And when he came to the water of Madyan, he found on it a group of men watering, and he found besides them two women keeping back (their flocks). He said: What is the matter with you? They said: We cannot water until the shepherds take away (their sheep) from the water, and our father is a very old man (28:23)

So, he watered (their sheep) for them, then went back to the shade and said: My Lord! surely, I stand in need of whatever good Thou mayest send down to me (28:24)

Then one of the two women came to him walking bashfully. She said: My father invites you that he may give you the reward of your having watered for us. So, when he came to him and gave to him the account, he said: Fear not, you are secure from the unjust people (28:25)

Said one of them: O my father! Employ him, surely, the best of those that you can employ is the strong man, the faithful one (28:26)

He said: I desire to marry one of these two daughters of mine to you on condition that you should serve me for eight years; but if you complete ten, it will be of your own free will, and I do not wish to be hard to you; if Allah please, you will find me one of the good (28:27)

He said: This shall be (an agreement) between me and you; whichever of the two terms I fulfill, there shall be no wrongdoing to me; and Allah is a witness of what we say (28:28)

So, when Musa had fulfilled the term, and he journeyed with his family, he perceived on this side of the mountain a fire. He said to his family: Wait, I have seen a fire, maybe I will bring to you from it some news or a brand of fire, so, that you may warm yourselves (28:29)

And when he came to it, a voice was uttered from the right side of the valley in the blessed spot of the bush, saying: O Musa! surely, I am Allah, the Lord of the worlds (28:30)

And saying: Cast down you staff. So, when he saw it in motion as if it were a serpent, he turned back retreating, and did not return. O Musa! come forward and fear not; surely, you are of those who are secure (28:31)

Enter your hand into the opening of your bosom, it will come forth white without evil, and draw your hand to yourself to ward off fear: so, these two shall be two arguments from your Lord to Fir'awn and his chiefs, surely, they are a transgressing people (28:32)

He said: My Lord! surely, I killed one of them, so, I fear lest they should slay me (28:33)

And my brother, Haroun, he is more eloquent of tongue than I, therefore send him with me as an aider, verifying me: surely, I fear that they would reject me (28:34)

He said: We will strengthen your arm with your brother, and We will give you both an authority, so, that they shall not reach you; (go) with Our signs; you two and those who follow you shall be uppermost (28:35)

So, when Musa came to them with Our clear signs, they said: This is nothing but forged enchantment, and we never heard

of it amongst our fathers of old (28:36)

And Musa said: My Lord knows best who comes with guidance from Him, and whose shall be the good end of the abode; surely, the unjust shall not be successful (28:37)

And Fir'awn said: O chiefs! I do not know of any god for you besides myself; therefore, kindle a fire for me, O Haman, for brick, then prepare for me a lofty building so, that I may obtain knowledge of Musa's god, and most surely, I think him to be one of the liars (28:38)

And he was unjustly proud in the land, he and his hosts, and they deemed that they would not be brought back to Us (28:39)

So, We caught hold of him and his hosts, then We cast them into the sea, and see how was the end of the unjust (28:40)

And We made them Imams who call to the fire, and on the day of resurrection they shall not be assisted (28:41)

And We caused a curse to follow them in this world, and on the day of resurrection they shall be of those made to appear hideous (28:42)

And certainly, We gave Musa the Book after We had destroyed the former generations, clear arguments for men and a guidance and a mercy, that they may be mindful (28:43)

And you were not on the western side when We revealed to Musa the commandment, and you were not among the witnesses (28:44)

But We raised up generations, then life became prolonged to them; and you were not dwelling among the people of Madyan, reciting to them Our communications, but We were the senders (28:45)

And you were not on this side of the mountain when We called, but a mercy from your Lord that you may warn a people to whom no warner came before you, that they may be mindful (28:46)

And were it not that there should befall them a disaster for what their hands have sent before, then they should say: Our Lord! why didst Thou not send to us a messenger so, that we should have followed Thy communications and been of the believers! (28:47)

But (now) when the truth has come to them from Us, they say: Why is he not given the like of what was given to Musa? What! did they not disbelieve in what Musa was given before? They say: Two magicians backing up each other; and they say: Surely, we are unbelievers in all (28:48)

Say: Then bring some (other) book from Allah which is a better guide than both of them, (that) I may follow it, if you are truthful (28:49)

But if they do not answer you, then know that they only follow their low desires; and who is more erring than he who follows his low desires without any guidance from Allah? Surely, Allah does not guide the unjust people (28:50)

We only emphasize some of the information of the verses as follows:

Pharaoh ruled with tyranny and cruelty. His policy was to divide people into various sects and use their disunity to rule. He killed men and their sons, and took their women to his service. God promises in the verse five that He wills the oppressed believers to be the inheritors and rulers of the world, so one day will come that the oppressed believers and the righteous will be the leaders who govern the worlds when the oppressors will be weakened. After that the oppressors and wrongdoers will not be able to rule the worlds (Tusi 1405 A.H., 1:731).

In verse five, God's promise is revealed. There may be a time when oppressors and tyrants rule over the world, but it is God's will that they will be weakened, and removed and replaced by believers and righteous people. After Moses reached a stage of physical, spiritual, and intellectual maturity God provided him with knowledge and wisdom to rule a nation. God emphasizes that he was a righteous and qualified person, which is why he was given the knowledge, wisdom, and position. Indeed, God knows who can perform such a duty (Tabataba'i 1417 A.H., 16:14).

A man who was oppressed asked Moses for help. In the process of helping him the oppressor was killed. Although Moses had the duty to help the oppressed, but one must always consider the conditions. Given the conditions the oppressed were already going through such a mistake was trouble. The man was oppressed once again, and without considering the situation complained to Moses again. This angered Moses for they were not in the right position to defend the oppressed just then.

Moses said to God that he wronged himself because even though helping the oppressed was his duty but it was not properly done, for the time was not right. He protected an oppressed person, but too much trouble ensued. God forgave

him, and Moses pledged never to protect the oppressors as a sign of gratitude to God. Indeed, Moses was a grateful servant.

Moses left town and aimlessly travelled through the land, asking God to guide him to the right road. On his journey, he arrived at a well surrounded by people who were watering their cattle, except for two women who modestly stood behind. They had come to water their father's cattle who was too old to stand with them, but they would not go forth for they did not want to mix with foreign men. They wanted to wait until everyone left. Moses offered his help and watered their sheep for them (Nakhjawani 1999, 2:80).

The two women turned out to be the daughters of Shu'ayb, a divine messenger in the city of Midian. They told their father about the event, and so Moses was invited to the house to receive his wage. The women shyly and politely went to Moses and delivered their father's message. At the meeting, Moses told his story to Shu'ayb, and Shu'ayb promised him safety. Shu'ayb was a messenger, he understood that Moses was a very righteous man, thus, he offered one of his two daughters to Moses on the condition that he would work for them for 8 years, but could be extended to 10 if Moses wanted. Thus, God provided Moses with a great teacher who trained and taught Moses for eight years.

Other teachings of the aforementioned verses can clearly be understood from the verses themselves, so we will not repeat them.

[13.](#) Between these places, Hajar, wife of Prophet Abraham, ran up and down seven times in search of water to her thirsty son, crying and praying to Allah. Allah answered her with a spring of water Zamzam gushed forth under Ismail. The rites and rituals are the same both for Hajj, pilgrimage, and Umrah, visit, with this difference that Hajj can be only performed on 9th of Dhil Hijah whilst Umrah can be performed on any day of the year.

[14.](#) . صاحب: يجمع بالصحب، و الصحبان و الصحبة و الصحاب. و الأصحاب: جماعة الصحب .

[15.](#) . صحب: صَحِبَهُ يَصْحَبُهُ صُحْبَةً، بالضم، و صَحَابَةً، بالفتح، و صاحبه: عاشره. و الصَّحْبُ: جمع الصحاب مثل راكب و ركب. و الأصحاب: . جماعة الصَّحْب مثل قَرْخ و أَفْرَاح. و الصحاب: المُعَاشر

[16.](#) See: Ibn Manzur 1414.

[17.](#) . Study the following words:

صَاحِبُكُمْ (53:12)

يَا صَاحِبِي السَّجَن (12:39)

إِذْ يَقُولُ لِصَاحِبِهِ لَا تَحْزَنْ (9:40)

(وَ كَانَ لَهُ كُفْرٌ فَقَالَ لِصَاحِبِهِ (18:34)

[18.](#) See: Qummi 1367 Sh.

[19.](#) See: S.-H. Tayyib 1378 A.H., Suyuti 1404 A.H.

[20.](#) See: Suyuti 1404 A.H.

[21.](#) See: 6: 125, 9: 14, 10:57,22:46, 11:5, 28:69, 29:49, 100:10, 114:5.

[22.](#) Explanation:

The people who are guided by God to Islam, the straight path, are the servants who have sought God's help for guidance. Through his mercy, God gives their heart the capacity to adhere to Islam. In other words, not everyone's heart has the capacity to embrace Islam. Those who disobey God and wrong themselves, arrogantly rejecting his signs, are disqualified to be guided to the true path. God closes their heart from Islam and it becomes difficult for them to accept God's command, as hard as flying in the sky (with respect to the time this verse was revealed).

[23.](#) See: a.-S. Tabataba'i 1417 A.H., F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh, Qummi 1367 Sh, Qurtubi al- 1364 Sh., A. I.-F. Razi, Rawdh al-jinan wa ruh al-jinan fi tafsir al-Qur'an 1408 A.H, Qurashshi 1371 Sh, Qurtubi al- 1364 Sh., Mustafaw 1360 Sh, Raghib Isfahani 1412 A.H.

[24.](#) Explanation:

The Qur'an is a holy book of guidance and directions for human life. God has created humans and other beings, and therefore provided them with programs and instructions to reach the summit of perfection in the world and hereafter. As humans, we have been given the power of intellect and thought, and by facilitating the teachings of God we can direct our thoughts and activities towards the strait path, if we follow the pillars below:

– Apply reason

– No one is allowed to oppress others

- Believers should be kind with each other, because they are brothers and sisters in their religion
 - People should avoid evil deeds
 - They should perform their religious duty as well as their duty in the family, society and etc. This means that our condition in the world and hereafter will improve if we use faith and reason
 - The teachings of the Qur'an keep human beings from violating the limits of humanity, in order to live in peace together
- To no surprise, the disbelievers disregarded the Qur'anic teachings. The prophet worried about them and what they would have to bear as the consequence their deeds. God calms the Prophet (S) by telling him that his mission is no more than warning the people, maybe they would listen and refrain from evil deeds, and that he is not responsible if they still decide to refrain from Qur'anic teachings. God explains that only believers, who are people who have decided to follow the Qur'an, will have faith in the Prophet (S).

25. The full Verse states the following:

قَالُوا إِنَّ يَسْرُقَ فَقَدْ سَرَقَ أَخٌ لَهُ مِنْ قَبْلُ فَأَسْرَهَا يُوسُفُ فِي نَفْسِهِ وَلَمْ يُبْدِهَا لَهُمْ قَالَ أَنْتُمْ شَرُّ مَكَانًا وَاللَّهُ أَعْلَمُ بِمَا تَصِفُونَ .

They said, "if he has stolen (it is not strange because) his brother had stolen before." But Joseph did not disclose it to them, and kept it secret in his heart. He said "you are in evil position i.e. the worst of the creatures and God is fully aware of what you allege.

Explanation:

When Josef took the cup out of the saddle bag of his brother, Benjamin, his other brothers whose mother was different from Joseph and Benjamin's mother condemned Benjamin. Their old feelings of jealousy was still flaming. They said Benjamin is a thief like his brother, Joseph. Their unjust words concerning Joseph and his brother saddened him but he did not disclose the fact, instead he told them that God is fully aware of what you say and you are in a worse condition; You are wrongdoers who wrongfully blame others while you have forgotten your own evil deeds.

26. See: Tabataba'i 1417A.H., 11:310, F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh, Tusi, Al-Tibyan fi tafsir al-Qur'an 1405 A.H, Tabari 1412 A.H., Qurashshi 1371 Sh.

27. The full Verse states the following:

وَتَوَلَّى عَنْهُمْ وَقَالَ يَا أَسَفَى عَلَى يُوسُفَ وَابْيَضَّتْ عَيْنَاهُ مِنَ الْحُزَنِ فَهُوَ كَظِيمٌ

28. See: Raghib Isfahani 1412 A.H.

29. See: M. Zamakhshari, Al-Kashshaf ʿan haqaʿiq ghawamidh al-tanzil 1407 A.H, F.-D. Razi, Mafatih al-ghayb 1420 A.H, Suyuti 1404 A.H.

30. As the previous note. The full Verse states the following:

وَتَوَلَّى عَنْهُمْ وَقَالَ يَا أَسَفَى عَلَى يُوسُفَ وَابْيَضَّتْ عَيْنَاهُ مِنَ الْحُزَنِ فَهُوَ كَظِيمٌ

And he turned away from them and he said (expressing the deep feeling of sorrow for Joseph), "Alas for Josef" and his eyes became white (blind) because of grief, he suppresses (his grief, and sorrow).

Explanation:

Jacob listened to what his children had to say, but he knew more than them. He knew Joseph was to attain a high position in the future, but he was worried Joseph would have to go through difficulties and problems. He was very sorrowful for losing Joseph. Although Jacob practiced patience and suppressed his grief, he still couldn't stop crying. He cried so much for Joseph he became blind.

31. See: Tabatabai 1350 AHS, Qurashshi 1371 Sh, Mustafaw 1360 Sh.

32. The full Verse states the following:

وَأَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ وَلَا تَنَازَعُوا فَتَفْشَلُوا وَتَذْهَبَ رِيحُكُمْ وَاصْبِرُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الصَّابِرِينَ

And obey God and His messenger and do not dispute lest you are defeated or lose honour, and have patience, indeed God is with the patients (helping).

Explanation:

This verse teaches how the Muslims should be strong and united:

- They should obey God and His messenger
- They should not dispute with each other and they should maintain the unity of Ummah
- They should exercise patience, that is, the difficulties must not deviate them from the straight path. They should obey God and the Messenger in all conditions, for if they do so God will be with them, because God is with the patients.

33. See: al-Mahalli and al-Suyuti n.d., F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh, Al-Qurtubi 1364 Sh, Razi 1420 A.H.

34. The full Verse states the following:

فَلَعَلَّكَ تَارِكٌ بَعْضَ مَا يُوحَىٰ إِلَيْكَ وَضَائِقٌ بِهِ صَدْرُكَ أَنْ يَقُولُوا لَوْلَا أُنْزِلَ عَلَيْهِ كُتُبٌ أَوْ جَاءَ مَعَهُ مَلَكٌ إِنَّمَا أَنْتَ نَذِيرٌ وَاللَّهُ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ وَكِيلٌ

And you may avoid to declare some of (the teachings) which is revealed to you and your heart may be heavy when they say “why has a treasure been sent down to him? Or why does not an angel come with him?” (Because) you are a warner and God is all-watchful over all things.

Explanation:

Disbelievers had the intention to disbelieve and offend the Prophet. They used pretexts to deny him; why hasn't God sent you a treasure, why isn't there an angel with you. This made the Prophet's heart heavy. He considered whether to delay delivering some of the messages, worrying that they may disobey and be punished for it later. The verse assures the Prophet that he must deliver the message on-time, regardless of whether they obey or not. This way they won't be able to bring excuses in the hereafter about being unaware of the law.

35. See: F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh, a.-S. Tabataba'i 1417 A.H.

36. The full Verse states the following:

لَيْسَ عَلَيْكَ هُدَاهُمْ وَلَكِنَّ اللَّهَ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشَاءُ وَمَا تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَلَا تُنْفُسُكُمْ وَمَا تُنْفِقُونَ إِلَّا ابْتِغَاءَ وَجْهِ اللَّهِ وَمَا تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ يُوَفَّ إِلَيْكُمْ وَاللَّهُ لَا يُظْلِمُونَ

Guiding them is not your duty but God guides whomever He wills, and what you spend out of good things is for yourselves, and only donate in order to attain God's pleasures, and what you donate of good things will be fully repaid to you and you will not be wronged.

Explanation:

God says to His Prophet that his duty is to explain and clarify God's signs, such as His commands, to the people (Ibn Abi Hatam 1419 A.H, 2:538). This is God who guides them, because the hearts are under His control and He will guide whoever He wills, that is, the submissive servants who follow His guidance will be guided (Ibn al-Qayyim 1406 A.H., 4:299).

The other point that God says is that He makes His servants certain that whatever they donate is helpful for them, but they should spend to attain God's pleasure; what they have spent will be repaid to them in full, and they will not be wronged (Faydh al-Kashani 1415 A.H., 1:300).

37. See: Qurashshi 1371 Sh, Mustafaw 1360 Sh, Al-Qurtubi 1364 Sh, Al-Suyuti 1404 A.H.

38. The full Verse states the following:

لِلْفُقَرَاءِ الَّذِينَ أُحْصِرُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ لَا يَسْتَطِيعُونَ ضَرْبًا فِي الْأَرْضِ يَحْسِبُهُمُ الْجَاهِلُ أَغْنِيَاءَ مِنَ التَّعَفُّفِ تَعْرِفُهُمْ بِسِيمَاهُمْ لَا يَسْأَلُونَ النَّاسَ إِلْحَافًا وَمَا تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ بِهِ عَلِيمٌ

(Donate to) the poor who have been strained on God's path, who are not able to travel on the land (for commerce). The ignorant imagines that they are rich because of their reserve, but you know them by their mark: they do not importunately demand (anything) from people. And what you spend out of good, indeed God knows it best.

Explanation:

God clarified the value of donation in the previous verses, here, He explains to whom we should donate i.e. There are some believers who are not able to travel for trade because they are busy on God's path:

They may be busy studying regarding religion.

They may have to wage jihad in God's path, so they cannot go for commerce.

The mentioned groups perform their duties and are needy, but they do not always ask for help or do so in an annoying way; hence the Muslims should take them into consideration and people should know that what they donate of good things, God sees and knows it best. And you will be rewarded by Him (Muqatil b. Sulayman 1423 A.H., 1:224-25).

39. The full Verse states the following:

الَّذِينَ يَأْكُلُونَ الرِّبَا لَا يَقُومُونَ إِلَّا كَمَا يَقُومُ الَّذِي يَتَخَبَّطُهُ الشَّيْطَانُ مِنَ الْمَسِّ ذَلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ قَالُوا إِنَّمَا الْبَيْعُ مِثْلُ الرِّبَا وَأَحَلَّ اللَّهُ الْبَيْعَ وَحَرَّمَ الرِّبَا فَمَنْ جَاءَهُ مَوْعِظَةٌ مِنْ رَبِّهِ فَانْتَهَى فَلَهُ مَا سَلَفَ وَأَمْرُهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَمَنْ عَادَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ أَصْحَابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيهَا خَالِدُونَ

Those who practice usury will not (be able to) to rise (from their grave before the Day of Judgment) except as the one who is crazed with Satan's touch, because they said, “Usury is (lawful,) similar to trade”; while God allows you to commerce, but he forbade practicing usury, so whoever received this advice from his Lord and gives it up, then he can possess what is past and his matter goes to God, but those who continue practicing usury will dwell in fire forever.

Explanation:

This verse explains the law of usury:

- a) Believers are not allowed to practice usury (Razi 1420 A.H, 7:72).
- b) Those that practice usury are sinful. They will rise from their grave on the Day of Judgment, like those who have been driven crazy with Satan's touch (Maybudi 1371 Sh, 1:747).
- c) The past of those who receive this advice and abandon it will be forgiven, and their matters will be resolved by God (Zamakhshari 1407 A.H, 1:321).
- d) Those who continue practicing usury will be the inmates of fire and reside there forever (Razi 1420 A.H, 7:79).

40. The full Verse states the following:

يَا أَهْلَ الْكِتَابِ لَا تَغْلُوا فِي دِينِكُمْ وَلَا تَقُولُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ إِلَّا الْحَقَّ إِنَّمَا الْمَسِيحُ عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ وَكَلِمَتُهُ أَلْقَاهَا إِلَى مَرْيَمَ وَرُوحٌ مِنْهُ فَآمِنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَلَا تَقُولُوا ثَلَاثَةٌ انْتَهُوا خَيْرًا لَكُمْ إِنَّمَا اللَّهُ إِلَهٌ وَاحِدٌ سُبْحَانَهُ أَنْ يَكُونَ لَهُ وَلَدٌ لَهُ مَا فِي السَّمَاوَاتِ وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ وَكَفَى بِاللَّهِ وَكِيلًا

O People of the Book! Do not exaggerate concerning your religion, and do not say anything about God but the truth.

Indeed, the Messiah, Jesus, son of Mary, is only God's messenger; His words, (creation), and the spirit from Him which God granted to Mary, so believe in God, His messengers and (give up exaggeration concerning your religion) do not say (that God is a) trinity. If you desist (from this belief) it is better for you (because) God certainly is the Lord (who is) One. Glory be to him!, and far be it from Him to have a child, and whatever exists in the Heavens and the earth belongs to God, and God is sufficient as a defender.

Explanation:

The most useful thing which leads the believers to paradise is true religion. To be guided to the true path one must follow the true religion. Exaggerating in religion is prohibited, for example, belief in the Trinity is misguidance because God is one, and The Messiah, Jesus, son of Mary, is only God's messenger, and along with the rest of the people, His servants. Hence, believers should refrain from exaggerating in religion, and refrain from believing in the Trinity because God is not physical or human and cannot have a child. God is so great that thoughts cannot imagine His reality and existence, but it is through ones' heart that one can understand that He exists.

41. The full Verse states the following:

وَقَالَ نِسْوَةٌ فِي الْمَدِينَةِ امْرَأَتُ الْعَزِيزِ تُرَاوِدُ فَتَاهَا عَنْ نَفْسِهِ ۖ قَدْ شَغَفَهَا حُبًّا إِنَّا لَنَرَاهَا فِي ضَلَالٍ مُبِينٍ

And the women in the town said "the wife of the master offered to have intercourse with her slave boy..... she is deeply in love with him. We think that she is in glaring error"

Explanation:

Zulaykhah dishonoured herself and her husband. Everybody was talking about her in the town and women in the town were saying that the wife of the master has burning love for her slave. Indeed she is stupid and has gone astray.

42. The full Verse states the following:

قُلْ يَا قَوْمِ اعْمَلُوا عَلَىٰ مَكَانَتِكُمْ إِنِّي عَامِلٌ ۖ فَسَوْفَ تَعْلَمُونَ

Say "O my people! (If you do not want to give up disobedience), do as much as you can and I will perform (my own duty), so you will come to know"

43. The full Verse states the following:

كَأَنَّ لَمْ يَغْنَوْا فِيهَا ۖ أَلَا بُعْدًا لِمَدْيَنَ كَمَا بَعِدَتِ ثَمُودُ

(They were destroyed) as if they did not exist before. May (the people of) Midian was far from (divine mercy) as Thamud was far away (from it)

Explanation:

Similar to previous tribes, a Prophet first used all means to teach the people and guide them to the right path, but if they refused they would threaten the tribe with Godly punishment in order to guide the few people left who would be guided, but in the end if the refusal continued, God's tradition to cleanse earth from the unpure would be carried out and the punishment would come. This tribe was no different and their time for punishment had arrived.

44. See Surah Hud, 11:44:

وَقِيلَ يَا أَرْضُ ابْلَعِي مَاءَكَ وَيَا سَّمَاءُ أَفْلَعِي وَغِيضَ الْمَاءِ وَقُضِيَ الْأَمْرُ وَاسْتَوَتْ عَلَى الْجُودِيِّ ۖ وَقِيلَ بُعْدًا لِلْقَوْمِ الظَّالِمِينَ

And it was said: O earth, swallow down your water, and O cloud, clear away; and the water was made to abate and the affair was decided, and the ark rested on the Judi, and it was said: Away with the unjust people.

45. The full Verse states the following:

إِذْ تَمْشِي أُخْتُكَ فَتَقُولُ هَلْ أَدُلُّكُمْ عَلَىٰ مَن يَكْفُلُهُ ۖ فَرَجَعْنَاكَ إِلَىٰ أُمِّكَ كَيْ تَقَرَّ عَيْنُهَا وَلَا تَحْزَنَ ۚ وَكَلَّمْتَ نَفْسًا فَنَجَّيْنَاكَ مِنَ الْغَمِّ وَفَتَنَّاكَ فُتُونًا ۚ فَلَبِثْتَ سِنِينَ فِي أَهْلِ مَدْيَنَ ثُمَّ جِئْتَ عَلَىٰ قَدَرٍ يَا مُوسَىٰ

When your sister went and said: Shall I direct you to one who will take charge of him? So We brought you back to your mother, that her eye might be cooled and she should not grieve and you killed a man, then We delivered you from the grief, and We tried you with (a severe) trying. Then you stayed for years among the people of Madyan; then you came hither as ordained, O Musa.

46. The full Verse states the following:

فَرَدَدْنَاهُ إِلَىٰ أُمِّهِ كَيْ تَقَرَّ عَيْنُهَا وَلَا تَحْزَنَ وَلِتَعْلَمَ أَنَّ وَعْدَ اللَّهِ حَقٌّ وَلَكِنَّ أَكْثَرَهُمْ لَا يَعْلَمُونَ

So We gave him back to his mother that her eye might be refreshed, and that she might no grieve, and that she might know that the promise of Allah is true, but most of them do not know.

47. The full Verse states the following:

لَقَدْ نَصَرَكُمُ اللَّهُ فِي مَوَاطِنَ كَثِيرَةٍ وَ يَوْمَ حُنَيْنٍ إِذْ أَعْجَبَتْكُمْ كَثْرَتُكُمْ فَلَمْ تُغْنِ عَنْكُمْ شَيْئًا وَ ضَاقَتْ عَلَيْكُمُ الْأَرْضُ بِمَا رَحُبَتْ ثُمَّ وَلَّيْتُم مُّذَبِّحِينَ

Indeed God has helped you in many places including in the battle of Hunayn when you were deceived by your multitude (of soldiers) but it could not protect you (against the enemy) and the wide earth seemed narrow for you (:you were in a very difficult situation), so you turned your back to the enemy, fleeing.

Explanation:

During the Battle of Hunayn, the Muslims had a huge and powerful army. They thought with themselves that such a gigantic force would be enough to settle the battle, they were overly proud. However this army proved otherwise. The army failed to protect them and they were overcome, some of the soldiers fled. This was because they put their trust in their army instead of God. They forgot God, the main helper.

48. The full Verse states the following:

وَلَنْ يَتَمَنَّوهُ أَبَدًا بِمَا قَدَّمَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ ۗ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِالظَّالِمِينَ

But they never long for death because they (committed sins before and) sent ahead by their hands. Indeed, God knows the wrongdoers best.

Explanation:

God rebuts their claim; they know themselves that their claim is false, and they are not the friends of God, so they never wish for death, because after death they will be punished (Faydh al-Kashani 1415 A.H., 1:166). God knows that they were wrong doers and intentionally commit sins, and they know that there awaits them painful punishment, so they never wish for death and God knows the evildoers (Maybudi 1371 Sh, 1:281).

49. See: 3:182, 4:62, 5:80, 8:51, 18:57, 22:10, 28:47, 30:36, 42:48, 59:18, 62:7, 78:40, and 82:5.

50. The full Verse states the following:

وَإِخْفِضْ جَنَاحَكَ لِمَنِ اتَّبَعَكَ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ

And extend your wing (of mercy) to any believer who follow you (be kind with them).

Explanation:

When the Messenger disclosed his mission, he was commanded to treat kindly with the believers, so kindness and mercy was a pillar in the behavior of the messenger.

51. The full Verse states the following:

عَالِمِ الْغَيْبِ وَالشَّهَادَةِ فَتَعَالَىٰ عَمَّا يُشْرِكُونَ

The knower of the unseen and the seen (and He is) above than (the partners) which they ascribe to Him.

Explanation:

God is not a human being and He needs nothing and nobody, so He has not chosen any one as His child. He is the only True Creator of the creation, the knower of the seen and the unseen above the partners which they ascribe to Him above that which people can think of it. There is no God beside Him because if there were more than one God they seek superiority over others and every God governs and control his own territory while we see there is a united system of ruling in the creation.

Chapter 3: A Study Of Problematic Structures In The English Translations Of The Qur'an

Structure

In every language, structures are used to convey meanings. Structures are unique to each language, therefore, the same structure cannot be used for translating text from source to target language, for it may produce wrong results or ones that are unpleasant to the reader.

In English language, structures usually look like this:

Subject + verb; e.g. Jonah came.

Gerund + verb or to be; e.g. Working hard is important.

To + verb + to be; e.g. To be silent is important.

Whereas in the Arabic language they look like this:

Verb+ subject; e.g. جاء زيد

Mubtada + khabar; e.g. زيد طبيب

Khabari muqaddam + Mubtada mu'akhkhar;

e.g.

لِلّٰهِ جُنُودُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَ الْأَرْضِ

And Allah's are the hosts of the heavens and the earth (48:7).

When translating text from Arabic to English, the difference in structures of each language must be considered, including:

- The style of text
- The differences between syntaxes and forms

In the example below, sentence A should be translated as demonstrated in b:

Verb + subject. E.g. ياكلون

Subject+ verb. E.g. They eat

Had we remained loyal to the Arabic structure the result would have been: eat them. This is what some Qur'an translators have sometimes done; fearing to change the structures used by the Qur'an, they used Arabic structures for the English language.

Why does that occur?

One must realize that Muslims are very sensitive about the Qur'an. In addition to the fact that the Qur'an is holy and it is a miracle, some translators also consider the style used in the Qur'an to also be holy and a miracle. As a result, betraying that style would be a betrayal of the sacredness and holiness of the Qur'an. However, what they miss is that the product of this approach may complicate the translation.

They have ignored what the Qur'an says:

وَمَا أَرْسَلْنَا مِنْ رَّسُولٍ إِلَّا بِلِسَانٍ قَوْمِهِ لِيُبَيِّنَ لَهُمْ فَيُضِلُّ اللَّهُ مَنْ يَشَاءُ وَ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشَاءُ وَ هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ

“And all the messengers that We send were (speaking) with the language of their people in order to clarify (God’s message) to them” (14:4).

The Qur'an clearly says that Godly messages are sent in the language of the people that are its recipients. God speaks with plain styles, structures, and forms because, as He says here, he wants to clarify His message to the people so that they become aware of their duties¹.

Therefore, a translation of the Qur'an must also be in a clear form. In conclusion, translators should be loyal to the target language and they should not use the structures and syntax of the source language in the target language.

We mention some examples and their translations to clarify what we have said.

وَلِلَّهِ مُلْكُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ

In Surah Aali Imran, 3:189 –

Qara’i: To Allah belongs the kingdom of the heavens and the earth.

Pickthall: Unto Allah belonged the Sovereignty of the heavens and the earth.

Arberry: To God belongs the Kingdom of the heavens and of the earth.

Sarwar: To God belongs all that is in the heavens.

The aforementioned verse is in standard Arabic, that is:

خبر مقدم (جارو مجرور) + مبتدأ مؤخر

لله: to God [belong]

ملك السموات و الارض

the Kingdom of the heavens and the earth.

It was said that the aforementioned verse is in standard Arabic, so it should be translated into Standard English. However, all the translators have used the structure of the Arabic language or used classic English.

We suggest two translations instead:

The kingdom of the heavens and the earth belongs to God.

The kingdom of the heavens and the earth is for God.

A standard sentence in English is: subject + verb, not: to+ noun + verb.

We mention difficult structures of the Qur'an, i.e., exclusive structures in Arabic, in order to find appropriate ways to convey Qur'an's message as complete as possible in English:

Mubtada And Khabar

Mubtada + Khabar constitutes a standard sentence in Arabic. Mubtada is a noun and usually comes at the beginning of the sentence and Khabar is a noun or phrase which is attributed to Mubtada.

They are applied in two ways as follows:

A) Mubtada + Khabar

e.g.

زيد حبيبي

Translation: Zayd is my friend

In the aforementioned sentence زيد is Mu'tada and حبيبي is Khabar.

B) Khabar, being Jarr u majrur, precedes Mu'tada. In this case, Mu'tada is called Mu'tadayi Mu'akhar and khabar is called Khabari Muqaddam.

Mu'tadayi Mu'akhar + Khabari Muqaddam

e.g.

لِلَّهِ جُنُودُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ

In Surah Al-Fath, 48:7.

جُنُودُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ

(The armies of the heaven and the earth) is Mu'tadayi Mu'akhar and لِلَّهِ (: for God) is Khabari Muqaddam.

Both these structures are considered standard plain Arabic, so they should be translated using standard Arabic too.

Suggested translation:

Correct: The armies of the heaven and the earth belong to God.

Incorrect: To God belong the armies of the heaven and the earth.

Now we study this standard Arabic structure in the translations of the Qur'an:

Shakir: And Allah's are the hosts of the heavens and the earth.

Irving: God (commands) the armies of Heaven and Earth.

Saffarzadeh: To Allah belong the hosts of the heavens and the earth.

Qara'i: To Allah belong the hosts of the heavens and the earth

Pickthall: Allah's are the hosts of the heavens and the earth.

Sarwar: To God belong the armies of the heavens and the earth. Yusuf Ali Allah belong the Forces of

the heavens and the earth.

Arberry: To God belong the hosts of the heavens and the earth.

Analysis:

As we see, some translators such as Qara'i, Arberry, Sarwar, and Saffarzadeh have used Arabic structures instead of Standard English structures. They have written (to God: Khabari Muqaddam) first, similar to the Arabic structure, whereas in English, the subject comes first.

Mubtadayi wasfi

اقائم زيد

اقائم is Khabar and precedes Mubtada, i.e. زيد. This form of Mubtada is called Mubtada wasfi^٤ and is a structure of the standard language of Arabic. The translator is not allowed to bring the verb (Khabar) before the subject (Mubtada), because, this is this feature belongs to standard Arabic, not Standard English.

e.g.

قَالَ أَرَأَيْبُ أَنْتَ عَنْ آلِهَتِي يَا إِبْرَاهِيمُ

In Surah Mariyam, 19:46 –

Arberry: Said he, what, art thou shrinking from my gods, Abraham?

Yusuf Ali: The father (replied: " Art thou shrinking from my gods, O Abraham?

Shakir: He said: Do you dislike my gods, O Ibraheem?

Irving: He said: " Do you dislike my gods, Abraham?

Saffarzadeh: His father said: " O, Ibrahim! Do you detest my gods?

Qara'i: He said, " Abraham! Are you renouncing my gods.

Pickthall: He said: Reject thou my gods, O Abraham?

Sarwar: His father replied, " Abraham, are you telling me to give-up my gods?

Analysis:

Even though the Khabar: (أُرَاغِبُ) precedes the Muftada: (أَنْتَ), the translators were careful and used Standard English. They have not put the verb before the subject and did not imitate the Arabic structure.

Sighah Al- Ta‘Ajjub

Arabs use the forms ما افعل or ب افعل when they want to show they are surprised at something, both of which are standard Arabic. Words that mean ‘surprise’ or ‘astonishment’ are not explicitly mentioned in this structure, which is exclusive to Arabic. In the Arabic syntax, this form is known as Sighah al- ta‘ajjub (form of a word for showing surprise).

فَمَا أَصْبَرَهُمْ عَلَى النَّارِ

In Surah Al-Baqara, 2: 175.

In this example, the Qur’an gives information about those who ignore divine signs and shows astonishment using the form ما أَصْبَرَ: how will they endure hell, their patience and endurance in the fire of the Hell, where they are eager to go, is surprising².

We shall analyse how this verse has been translated by other translators:

Shakir: How bold they are to encounter fire!

Irving: Why do they insist on facing the Fire?

Saffarzadeh: how daring they are in bearing the Fire!

Qara’i: how patient of them to face the Fire!

Pickthall: How constant are they in their strife to reach the Fire!

Yusuf Ali: what boldness they show for the Fire!

Arberry: how patiently they shall endure the Fire!

Analysis:

Some translators, such as Irving, have failed to successfully convey the meaning of this structure, whereas the rest, such Saffarzadeh and Yusuf Ali, have conveyed the meaning successfully.

Suggested translation:

What an endurance they have against the fire!

Tamyiz

In Arabic syntax, Tamyiz is a noun which clarifies the preceding ambiguity.

e.g.

عندى رطل ماء

ماء is a noun and means water. It is the Tamyiz of this sentence. The literal translation of the sentence is: before me is a bowl, water. You see that the literal translation is ambiguous. To have a clear translation, we explain the meaning of the sentence and the role of Tamyiz:

According to the aforementioned sentence there is a bowl with unknown content. Tamyiz clarifies the content; water. Therefore, we have a bowl of water. As it is clear from the example, translating such phrases literally and ignoring the differences between two languages fails to produce an acceptable translation. The meaning will become confusing.

The following translations is suggested:

I have a bowl of water.

Or

There is a bowl of water with me.

We shall study this structure (Tamyiz) in some of Qur'anic verses.

وَكَفَىٰ بِاللَّهِ حَسِيبًا...

In Surah an-Nisa', 4:6.[3](#)

حَسِيبًا is tamyiz. The verse says that God is enough, but enough for what? He is enough as a reckoner. We suggest the verse to be translated, "As a reckoner, God is enough" or "God's reckoning is sufficient."

Translations:

Sarwar: God is Sufficient in keeping the account.

Shakir: Allah is sufficient to take account.

Irving: God suffices as a Reckoner

Saffarzadeh: Allah's Taking account is only what matters.

Qara'i: Allah suffices as reckoner.

Pickthall: Allah keeps good account.

Yusuf Ali: And enough is Allah to call) men (to account).

Arberry: God suffices as a reckoner.

Analysis:

According to what we mentioned, the translations of Arberry, Qara'i, and Irving are better than the rest. The rest have room for improvement, that is, Arabic syntax has influenced their translation.

Another example:

إِنَّا جَعَلْنَا مَا عَلَى الْأَرْضِ زِينَةً لَهَا لِنَبْلُوهُمْ أَيُّهُمْ أَحْسَنُ عَمَلًا

In Surah Al-Kahf, 18:7.

Translations:

Shakir: Surely, We have made whatever is on the earth an embellishment for it, so that We may try them as to which of them is best in works.

Irving: We have placed whatever is on earth as an ornament for it so We may test them as to which one is best in action.

Saffarzadeh: Verily, all that We have created on the earth is but attractive decorations For it; in order that We may test men How they choose the spiritual values Over those materialistic attractions; and How they race the line of good conduct.

Qara'i: Indeed, We have made whatever is on the earth an adornment for it that We may test them to see which of them is best in conduct

Pickthall: Lo! We have placed all that is on the earth as an ornament thereof that We may try them: which of them is best in conduct

Sarwar: We have caused earthly things to seem attractive so that We can see who will excel in good deeds.

Yusuf Ali: That which is on earth we have made but as a glittering show for it, in order that We may test them – – as to which of them are best in conduct. Arberry: We have appointed all that is on the earth for

an adornment for it, and that We may try which of them is fairest in works.

Analysis:

The verse raises a hidden question. God tests human beings in order to see which of them is best? Best in what? The answer is: practice.

We suggest the following translation for this verse:

...In order that We may test (to see) who practices best.

We should try to convey the meaning in a clear and simple way in Standard English. It would be unsuitable for a translator to impose Arabic structures on the English by translating literally. Not that the translations above are wrong, but they could have been clearer.

Example:

فَضَرَبْنَا عَلَى آذَانِهِمْ فِي الْكَهْفِ سِنِينَ عَدَدًا

In Surah Al-Kahf, 18:11.

Translations:

Shakir: So We prevented them from hearing in the cave for a number of years.

Irving: We struck them with drowsiness in the Cave for several years.

Qara'i ... several years.

Saffarzadeh, Pickthall, Sarwar, Yusuf Ali: ... a number of years.

Arberry: ...many years.

Analysis:

It seems all translators have observed the English grammar. The translations are acceptable.

Another example:

نَحْنُ نَقُصُّ عَلَيْكَ نَبَأَهُم بِالْحَقِّ ۚ إِنَّهُمْ فِتْيَةٌ آمَنُوا بِرَبِّهِمْ وَزِدْنَاهُمْ هُدًى

In Surah Al-Kahf, 18:13.

Translations:

Shakir: We relate to you their story with the truth surely they were youths who believed in their Lord and We increased them in guidance.

Qara'i, Yusuf Ali: and We had enhanced them in guidance.

Pickthall: ... and We increased them in guidance.

Arberry: and We increased them in guidance.

Sarwar: ... and We gave them further guidance.

Irving: ... and We gave them extra guidance.

Saffarzadeh: ...We increased the Guidance for them.

Analysis:

This verse says that the young who had believed in God and had left the polytheists were rewarded by God by increased guidance.

The translations do not seem wrong. In English, 'guidance' is used with the following collocations:

- Additional guidance
- Further guidance

And with the following words:

- Provide with
- Offer
- Give

So we can translate the aforementioned verse as follows:

- We increased their guidance.
- We provided them with further guidance

Example:

كَالَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ كَانُوا أَشَدَّ مِنْكُمْ قُوَّةً وَآكَثَرَ أَمْوَالًا وَأَوْلَادًا فَاسْتَمْتَعُوا بِخَلْقِهِمْ فَاسْتَمْتَعْتُمْ بِخَلْقِكُمْ كَمَا اسْتَمْتَعَ الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ بِخَلْقِهِمْ وَخُضْتُمْ كَالَّذِي خَاضُوا ۚ أُولَٰئِكَ حَبِطَتْ أَعْمَالُهُمْ فِي الدُّنْيَا وَالْآخِرَةِ ۚ وَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْخَاسِرُونَ

In Surah At-Tawba, 9:69.

Three words, i.e. أَوْلَادًا ، أَمْوَالًا ، قُوَّةً, are Tamyiz and clarify how the predecessors were greater.

Translations:

Qara'i: Hypocrites! Your case is [similar to those who were before you], who were more powerful than you and more abounding in wealth and children: they enjoyed their share [of worldly existence]; you too enjoy your share, just like those who were before you enjoyed their share, and you have gossiped [impiously] as they gossiped. They are the ones whose works have failed in this world and the Hereafter; and it is they who are the losers

Shakir: Like those before you; they were stronger than you in power and more abundant in wealth and children...

Irving: Just as those before them were firmer than you are in strength, and possessed more wealth and children, and they exploited their advantage...

Saffarzadeh: Those disbelievers and hypocrites who lived before you were even stronger than you in might and more affluent than you in wealth and they had more Children....

Pickthall: Even as those before you who were mightier than you in strength, and more affluent than you in wealth and children...

Sarwar: like that of those who lived before you, whose power, wealth, and children were much greater than yours.

Yusuf Ali: As in the case of those before you: they were mightier than you in power, and more flourishing in wealth and children...

Arberry: Like those before you, who were stronger than you in might, and more abundant in wealth and children.

Analysis:

Even though all the translations are correct, but most of them have used the preposition of (in), i.e. in wealth, in children, and in power, to convey the meaning of the phrase, which has been applied in the form of Tamyiz. It seems the translations have been influenced by the Arabic structure and could have been clearer if it had been within the syntax of Standard English, similar to Sarwar.

Suggested translation:

...those who were more powerful and wealthier than you with more children than you.

Example:

قُلْ أَيُّ شَيْءٍ أَكْبَرُ شَهَادَةً قُلِ اللَّهُ شَهِيدٌ بَيْنِي وَبَيْنَكُمْ

In Surah Al-Anam, 6:19⁴

Translations:

Shakir: Say: What thing is the weightiest in testimony? Say: Allah He is witness between you and me.

Irving: Say: "What thing is most important as evidence?" SAY: "God is a Witness for both me and you.

Saffarzadeh: Say [O, Messenger!]: "What is greatest As an evidence?" Say: "Allah's and Allah is Witness between me and you.

Qara'i: Say, "What thing is greatest as witness?" Say, "Allah! He is witness between me and you.

Pickthall: Say (O Muhammad): What thing is of most weight in testimony? Say: Allah is Witness between me and you.

Sarwar: (Muhammad), ask them, "What is the greatest testimony? God testifies of my truthfulness to you.

Yusuf Ali: Say: "What thing is most weighty in evidence?" Say: "Allah is witness between me and you

Arberry: Say: What thing is greatest in testimony? Say: God He is witness between me and you.

Analysis:

Here Tamyiz shows the quality or importance of testimony, asking whose testimony is greater: God or

others? All the translations could have been clearer, because the translations have been influenced by the Arabic structure.

Suggested translations:

What thing gives greater testimony?

What thing gives better testimony?

What testimony is greater?

What thing testifies better?

Who testifies better?

Jarr -u- Majrur

In standard Arabic, when Jarr-u-majrur (Harf al-jarr and Ism al-majrur) is Khabar it precedes Muftada, but when translated, the Arabic structure must not be imitated, because sentences do not tend to begin with preposition + noun in standard English:

جار و مجرور (خبر مقدم) + مبتدأ مؤخر

e.g.

لسليمان جمل

Literal translation: to Solomon is a camel.

Suggested translation: Solomon has a camel.

e.g.

لِلرِّجَالِ نَصِيبٌ مِّمَّا اكْتَسَبُوا وَلِلنِّسَاءِ نَصِيبٌ مِّمَّا اكْتَسَبْنَ

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:32⁵

Translations:

Shakir: Men shall have the benefit of what they earn and women shall have the benefit of what they earn.

Irving: Men should have a portion of whatever they have earned, while women should have a portion of whatever they have earned.

Saffarzadeh: To the men a Share from what they have earned and To the women a share from what they Have earned.

Qara'i: To men belongs a share of what they have earned, and to women a share of what they have earned.

Pickthall: Unto men a fortune from that which they have earned, and unto women a fortune from that which they have earned.

Sarwar: Men and women will both be rewarded according to their deeds

Yusuf Ali: To men is allotted what they earn, and to women what they earn.

Arberry: To the men a share from what they have earned and to the women a share from what they have earned.

Analysis:

Shakir, Irving, and Sarwar used Standard English structures but other translations began their sentence with preposition + noun, which is not Standard English. It seems their translations have been influenced by Arabic syntax.

Maf'ul Mutlaq

There are three types of Maf'ul Mutlaq in Arabic and the translations of each one is different:

Maf'ul Mutlaqi Ta'kidi

When a word of the same root is repeated after the verb, it is known as Maf'ul Mutlaq. If Maf'ul Mutlaq is used to emphasize the verb it is called as Maf'ul Mutlaqi Ta'kidi.

Maf'ul Mutlaqi Nu'i

Maf'ul Mutlaqi Nu'i indicates the type or quality of its A'mil (preceding verb).

e.g.

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا تَوْبُوا إِلَى اللَّهِ تَوْبَةً نَّصُوحًا عَسَىٰ رَبُّكُمْ أَن يُكَفِّرَ عَنْكُمْ سَيِّئَاتِكُمْ وَيُدْخِلَكُم جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ

In Surah At-Tahrim, 66:86

The verb (تُوبُوا) commands the believers to repent and the Maf'ul Mutlaqi Nu'i (i.e. تَوْبَةً نَّصُوحاً) shows the quality of repentance.

Translations:

Shakir: O you who believe! Turn to Allah a sincere turning; maybe your Lord will remove from you your evil and cause you to enter gardens beneath which rivers flow.

Qara'i: O you who have faith! Repent to Allah with sincere repentance!

Irving: You who believe, turn to God in frank repentance.

Saffarzadeh: [O, you who believe!] If you desire to be Immune from the bad end, then avoid Wrongdoing while you are in this world [Submit your repentance to Allah with a Sincere Repentance]

Pickthall: O ye who believe! Turn unto Allah in sincere repentance!

Sarwar: Believers, turn to God in repentance with the intention of never repeating the same sin.

Yusuf Ali: O ye who believe! Turn to Allah with sincere repentance:

Arberry: Believers, turn to God in sincere repentance.

Analysis:

All the translators paid attention to the meaning of the aforementioned structure, i.e. Maf'ul Mutlaqi Nu'i, and it seems all the translations are acceptable.

Another example:

إِنْ تَجْتَنِبُوا كَبَائِرَ مَا تُنْهَوْنَ عَنْهُ نُكَفِّرْ عَنْكُمْ سَيِّئَاتِكُمْ وَنُدْخِلَكُمْ مُدْخَلَ كَرِيمٍ

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:31.

The word مُدْخَلَ can either be a gerund (Masdar) or an adverb which showing a place (Qid al-makan)⁷. If it is a gerund then the role of مُدْخَلَ كَرِيمٍ in this verse would be Maf'ul Mutlaqi Nu'i:

Translations:

Shakir: If you shun the great sins which you are forbidden, We will do away with your small sins and cause you to enter an honourable place of entering.

Irving: If you will avoid the great [sins] you are forbidden [to commit], We will cancel out your [other] evil deeds for you, and send you into] Paradise through a noble entrance.

Saffarzadeh: If you avoid the grave sins which You are forbidden to do, We will remit From you, your small misdeeds and Admit you to the Glorious Gate.

Qara'i: If you avoid the major sins that you are forbidden, We will absolve you of your misdeeds, and admit you to a noble abode.

Pickthall: If ye avoid the great [things] which ye are forbidden, We will remit from you your evil deeds and make you enter at a noble gate.

Yusuf Ali: If ye but eschew the most heinous of the things which ye are forbidden to do, We shall remit your evil deeds, and admit you to a Gate of great honour

Sarwar: If you avoid violating that which has been prohibited, your lesser sins will be forgiven and you will be admitted into an exalted dwelling.

Arberry: If you avoid the heinous sins that are forbidden you, We will acquit you of your evil deeds, and admit you by the gate of honour.

Analysis:

Irving took مُدْخَلًا كَرِيْمًا as Maf'ul Mutlaqi Nu'i and translated it correctly. Other translators took مُدْخَلًا as an adverb showing the position (i.e. Qid al-makan), and have accordingly given acceptable translations.

Maf'ul Mutlaqi 'Adadi

This category of Maf'ul Mutlaqi indicates the quantity or number of its 'Amil (e.g. verb).

وَحُمِلَتِ الْأَرْضُ وَالْجِبَالُ فَدُكَّتَا دَكَّةً وَاحِدَةً

In Surah Al-Haqqa, 69: 14.

Translations:

Shakir: And the earth and the mountains are borne away and crushed with a single crushing.

Irving: And the earth is lifted up along with the mountains and they are both flattened by a single blow.

Saffarzadeh: The earth and the mountains shall be Removed and crashed with a single Stroke of shake.

Qara'i: and the earth and the mountains are lifted and levelled with a single levelling.

Yusuf Ali: And the earth is moved, and its mountains, and they are crushed at one stroke.

Pickthall: And the earth with the mountains shall be lifted up and crushed with one crash.

Sarwar: The earth and mountains will be raised up high and crushed all together.

Arberry: and the earth and the mountains are lifted up and crushed with a single blow.

Analysis:

دَكَّتْ وَاحِدَةً is Maf'ul Mutlaqi 'Adadi and it indicates the number of دُكَّتَا (verb). According to what we have explained, all the translators have given acceptable translations, except Sarwar who has not translated it altogether.

Maf'ulun lah

Maf'ulun lah is a single noun in Arabic syntax which indicates the cause of the preceding statement. We study the translation of this structure in the following verse:

...وَالَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوَالَهُمْ رِئَاءَ النَّاسِ

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:38⁸

This verse states that they spend their wealth in order to show off.

Translations:

Shakir: And those who spend their property) in alms (to be seen of the people

Irving: who spend their wealth to be seen by other people.

Saffarzadeh: Those who spend their property in Charity to show off to people.

Qara'i: And those who spend their wealth to be seen by people.

Pickthall: And [also] those who spend their wealth in order to be seen of men.

Sarwar: those who spend their property out of a desire to show off.

Yusuf Ali: Not those who spend of their substance, to be seen of men.

Arberry: and such as expend of their substance to show off to men.

Analysis:

رِئَاءَ النَّاسِ is the reason of the previous statement, i.e. وَالَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوَالَهُمْ, because رِئَاءَ is Maf'ulun lah. All translators have translated this syntax correctly.

Hal

In Arabic grammar, Hal (adverb) is a noun or a phrase that indicates a state, condition, or position of Zulhal, i.e. a phrase or noun which Hal refers to. In Arabic, Hal can be subject, object, Khabar, or Majrur. We shall study the different types of Hal in the Qur'an:

يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ أَنْ يُخَفِّفَ عَنْكُمْ ۖ وَخُلِقَ الْإِنْسَانُ ضَعِيفًا

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:28.

Translations:

Shakir: Allah desires that He should make light your burdens and man is created weak.

Irving: God wants to lighten things for you, since man was created weak!

Saffarzadeh: Allah Wills to lighten the burdens of punishment for you; for man was Created weak [in resolution].

Sarwar: God wants to relieve you of your burden; all human beings were created weak.

Yusuf Ali: Allah doth wish to lighten your difficulties For man was created weak in resolution⁹.

Qara'i Allah desires to lighten your burden, for man was created weak.

Arberry: God desires to lighten things for you for man was created a weakling.

Pickthall: Allah would make the burden light for you, for man was created weak.

Analysis:

The word ضَعِيفًا is a singular hal (adverb in the form of a noun), indicating the state in which Man has been created, i.e. weak. Man is weak. However, some translators such as Arberry, Qara'i, Yusuf Ali, Saffarzadeh and Irving have not translated the meaning laid in this structure. They have translated ضَعِيفًا as a M'fulun lah, which shows the reason for the statement which comes before

Example:

وَابْتَئُوا الْيَتَامَىٰ حَتَّىٰ إِذَا بَلَغُوا النِّكَاحَ فَإِنْ آنَسْتُمْ مِنْهُمْ رُشْدًا فَادْفَعُوا إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوَالَهُمْ ۖ وَلَا تَأْكُلُوهَا إِسْرَافًا وَبِدَارًا

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:6¹⁰

Translations:

Shakir: And test the orphans until they attain puberty; then if you find in them maturity of intellect, make over to them their property" And do not consume it extravagantly and hastily.

Irving: Test orphans as soon as they reach a marriageable age. If you are sure of their maturity, then turn their property over to them; do not use it up extravagantly, overanxious

Saffarzadeh: And test orphans, regarding their Intelligence and maturity until they Reach the age of marriage; then if you Find sound judgment in them, deliver Their heritage to them, but do not Consume it wastefully and hastily,

Qara'i: Test the orphans when they reach the age of marriage. Then if you discern in them maturity, deliver to them their property. And do not consume it lavishly and hastily

Sarwar: Before returning orphan's property to them, make sure that they have reached maturity. Do not consume their property wastefully until such a time.

Pickthall: Prove orphans till they reach the marriageable age; then, if ye find them of sound judgment, deliver over unto them their fortune; and devour it not by squandering and in haste.

Yusuf Ali Make trial of orphans until they reach the age of marriage; if then ye find sound judgment in them, release their property to them; but consume it not wastefully, nor in haste.

Arberry: Test well the orphans, until they reach the age of marrying; then, if you perceive in them right judgment, deliver to them their property consume it not wastefully and hastily.

Analysis:

Two words اسرافا و بدارا are Hal (adverb) and refer to Dhul Hal, which is لَا تَأْكُلُوهَا. The verse means: Do not consume it wastefully and hastily. Translators such as Arberry, Qara'i, Saffarzadeh, and Shakir have paid attention to this structure more than other translators, nevertheless, all the translations are correct.

Example:

وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذَلِكَ عُدْوَانًا وَظُلْمًا فَسَوْفَ نُصْلِيهِ نَارًا ۚ وَكَانَ ذَلِكَ عَلَى اللَّهِ يَسِيرًا

In Surah An-Nisa', 4:30.

يَفْعَلْ وَ عُدْوَانًا وَ ظُلْمًا are Hal (adverb) which refer to هو (Dhul Hal) in

Translations:

Shakir: And whoever does this aggressively and unjustly, We will soon cast him into fire And this is easy to Allah.

Irving: we shall roast anyone in a Fire who does so out of enmity and wrongfully. That will be easy for God to do.

Saffarzadeh: And whoever does that, out of Aggression and injustice, We shall cast Him into the Hell Fire and that is An easy matter for Allah.

Qara'i: And whoever does that in aggression and injustice, We will soon make him enter the Fire, and that is easy for Allah

Pickthall: Whoso doeth that through aggression and injustice, we shall cast him into Fire, and that is ever easy for Allah.

Sarwar: Whoever commits murder out of animosity and injustice will be burnt in hell fire. This is a very easy thing for God to do.

Yusuf Ali: If any do that in rancor and injustice, soon shall We cast them into the Fire: And easy it is for Allah.

Arberry: But whosoever does that in transgression and wrongfully, him We shall certainly roast at a Fire and that for God is an easy matter.

Analysis:

The translations are not wrong, but the translation of Shakir seems to be more accurate.

Suggested translation:

Whoever does that aggressively and wrongfully, We will make him enter Fire.

Or

Whoever does that while he is aggressive and wrongful, We will make him enter fire.

Emphasis

In Arabic, different types of structures are used to emphasize on something. We shall study these structures with their translations.

Different types of emphasizing in Arabic:

A)

...+ لا + اسم + إلا

Example:

قَالُوا سُبْحَانَكَ لَا عِلْمَ لَنَا إِلَّا مَا عَلَّمْتَنَا ۖ إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ الْعَلِيمُ الْحَكِيمُ

In Surah Al-Baqara, 2:32.

Translations:

Shakir: They said: Glory be to Thee! We have no knowledge but that which Thou hast taught us;" Surely Thou art the Knowing, the Wise.

Qara'i: They said, "Immaculate are You! We have no knowledge except what You have taught us. Indeed, You are the All-knowing, the All-wise.

Pickthall: They said: Be glorified! We have no knowledge saving that which Thou hast taught us. Lo! Thou, only Thou, art the Knower, the Wise.

Irving: They said: "Glory be to You; we have no knowledge except whatever You have taught us

Analysis:

Suggested translation:

... Our knowledge is only that which you have taught us...

The translations are not wrong but they have been affected by the Arabic structure. It would have been better if they had simply used English structures for emphasizing.

B)

إِنْ + فعل + لام

Example:

وَأِنَّا إِن شَاءَ اللَّهُ لَمُهْتَدُونَ

In Surah Al-Baqara, 2:70¹¹.

Translations:

Shakir: and if Allah pleases we shall surely be guided aright.

Pickthall: and Lo! If Allah wills, we may be led aright.

Irving: and we should be guided properly, if God so wishes.

Saffarzadeh: and we shall then be guided, if Allah Wills.

Qara'i: and, if Allah wishes, we will surely be guided.

Sarwar: so that God willing, we shall have the right description

Yusuf Ali: We wish indeed for guidance, if Allah wills.

Arberry: and, if God will, we shall then be guided.

Analysis:

Two words have been used to as a way to emphasize in this verse: إِنَّ (indeed) and لَمْ يَهْتَدُوا (surely, definitely). However, none of the translators mention both these emphasizing. Some of the translators including Qara'i and Shakir mentioned the emphasis of لَمْ يَهْتَدُوا but not إِنَّ, while some translators have ignored both.

Suggested translation:

Indeed, we will be guided for sure, if God wills.

C)

ما + فعل + إلا + اسم

E.g.

وَلَقَدْ أَنْزَلْنَا إِلَيْكَ آيَاتٍ بَيِّنَاتٍ ۚ وَمَا يَكْفُرُ بِهَا إِلَّا الْفَاسِقُونَ

In Surah Al-Baqara, 2:99.

Translations:

Pickthall: Verily We have revealed unto thee clear tokens, and only miscreants will disbelieve in them.

Qara'i: We have certainly sent down manifest signs to you, and no one defies them except transgressors.

Shakir: And none disbelieve in them except the transgressors.

Irving: Only immoral people disbelieve in them.

Saffarzadeh: And none disbelieve in them but the wrongdoers.

Sarwar: Only the wicked sinners deny it.

Yusuf Ali: and none reject them but those who are perverse.

Arberry: and none disbelieves in them except the ungodly.

Analysis:

According to the aforementioned structure, the verse emphasizes that only transgressors (الْفَاسِقُونَ) disbelieve in the signs of God. The translations of Pickthall, Sarwar, and Irving are better and clearer than the rest.

D)

لَنْ + فعل + أَبَدًا

E.g.

وَلَنْ يَتَمَنَّوْهُ أَبَدًا بِمَا قَدَّمَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ ۗ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِالظَّالِمِينَ

In Surah Al-Baqara, 2:95.

Translations:

Shakir: And they will never invoke it on account of what their hands have sent before And Allah knows the unjust.

Irving: They will never long for it...

Qara'i: But they will not long for it ever...

Pickthall: But they will never long for it...

Saffarzadeh: But they will never long for death,

Sarwar: But they can never have a longing for death...

Yusuf Ali: But they will never seek for death...

Arberry: But they will never long for it.

Analysis:

لَنْ means never and أَبَدًا means ever. لَنْ indicates impossibility in the future, it seems the translations are clear and acceptable.

E)

لَ + فعل + نَّ

لَ + تَجِدَ + نَّ

لَ and نَّ are attached to the verb and used separately in order to emphasize. It is important to note how the verb has been translated in the verse below:

وَلَتَجِدَنَّهُمْ أَحْرَصَ النَّاسِ عَلَى حَيَاةٍ

In Surah Al-Baqara, 2:96¹².

Translations:

Qara'i: Surely, you will find them the greediest for life,

Pickthall: And thou wilt find them greediest of mankind for life and greedier [than the idolaters].

Shakir: And you will most certainly find them the greediest of men for life) greedier (than even those who are polytheists...

Irving: You will find them the people most eager to live, even compared with those who associate others with God...

Saffarzadeh: And O, Messenger! Verily, you will find The Jews, the greediest for life and even greedier than the idolaters...

Sarwar: However, you will find them the greediest of all men, even more than the pagans, for life...

Yusuf Ali: Thou wilt indeed find them, of all people, most greedy of life...

Arberry: and thou shalt find them the eagerest of men for life and of the idolaters...

Analysis:

Some translators such as Arberry, Sarwar, and Irving have not mentioned the emphasis at all. Some, such as Qara'i, have failed to demonstrate the strong emphasis that exists in this verse. However, the translation of Shakir can be considered as an acceptable one.

Suggested translation:

Indeed, you definitely find them the greediest of [people] for life.

1. See: Qurtubi 1364 Sh., v. 10, p. 340.

2. See: Tusi, Al-Tibyan fi tafsir al-Qur'an 1405 A.H, v. 2, p. 90.

3. The full Verse states the following:

﴿وَابْتَلُوا الْيَتَامَىٰ حَتَّىٰ إِذَا بَلَغُوا النِّكَاحَ فَإِنْ آنَسْتُمْ مِنْهُمْ رُشْدًا فَادْفَعُوا إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوَالَهُمْ ۖ وَلَا تَأْكُلُوهَا إِسْرَافًا وَبِدَارًا أَن يَكْبَرُوا ۚ وَمَن كَانَ غَنِيًّا فَلْيَسْتَغْفِرْ ۖ وَمَن كَانَ فَقِيرًا فَلْيَأْكُلْ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ ۚ فَإِذَا دَفَعْتُمْ إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوَالَهُمْ فَأَشْهَدُوا عَلَيْهِمْ ۚ وَكَفَىٰ بِاللَّهِ حَسِيبًا ۝﴾

And test the orphans until they attain puberty; then if you find in them maturity of intellect, make over to them their property, and do not consume it extravagantly and hastily, lest they attain to full age; and whoever is rich, let him abstain altogether, and whoever is poor, let him eat reasonably; then when you make over to them their property, call witnesses in their presence; and Allah is enough as a Reckoner.

4. The full Verse states the following:

﴿قُلْ أَيُّ شَيْءٍ أَكْبَرُ شَهَادَةً ۖ قُلِ اللَّهُ ۖ شَهِيدٌ بَيْنِي وَبَيْنَكُمْ ۖ وَأُوحِيَ إِلَيَّ هَٰذَا الْقُرْآنُ لِأُنذِرَكُمْ بِهِ وَمَن بَلَغَ ۖ أَنتُمْ لَتَشْهَدُونَ أَنَّ مَعَ اللَّهِ إِلَهَةً أُخْرَىٰ ۖ قُلْ لَا أَشْهَدُ ۖ قُلْ إِنَّمَا هُوَ إِلَهُ وَاحِدٌ وَإِنِّي بَرِيءٌ مِّمَّا تُشْرِكُونَ ۝﴾

Say: What thing is the weightiest in testimony? Say: Allah is witness between you and me; and this Quran has been revealed to me that with it I may warn you and whomsoever it reaches. Do you really bear witness that there are other gods with Allah? Say: I do not bear witness. Say: He is only one Allah, and surely I am clear of that which you set up (with Him).

5. The full Verse states the following:

﴿وَلَا تَتَمَنَّوْا مَا فَضَّلَ اللَّهُ بِهِ بَعْضُكُمْ عَلَىٰ بَعْضٍ ۚ لِلرِّجَالِ نَصِيبٌ مِّمَّا اكْتَسَبُوا ۚ وَلِلنِّسَاءِ نَصِيبٌ مِّمَّا اكْتَسَبْنَ ۚ وَاسْأَلُوا اللَّهَ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كَانَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمًا ۝﴾

And do not covet that by which Allah has made some of you excel others; men shall have the benefit of what they earn and women shall have the benefit of what they earn; and ask Allah of His grace; surely Allah knows all things.

6. The full Verse states the following:

﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا آمِنُوا تُوبُوا إِلَى اللَّهِ تَوْبَةً نَّصُوحًا عَسَىٰ رَبُّكُمْ أَن يُكَفِّرَ عَنْكُمْ سَيِّئَاتِكُمْ وَيُدْخِلَكُمْ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ يَوْمَ لَا يُخْزِي اللَّهُ النَّبِيَّ وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا مَعَهُ ۖ نُورُهُمْ يَسْعَىٰ بَيْنَ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَبِأَيْمَانِهِمْ يَقُولُونَ رَبَّنَا أَتْمِمْ لَنَا نُورَنَا وَاغْفِرْ لَنَا ۖ إِنَّكَ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ ۝﴾

O you who believe! turn to Allah a sincere turning; maybe your Lord will remove from you your evil and cause you to enter gardens beneath which rivers flow, on the day on which Allah will not abase the Prophet and those who believe with him; their light shall run on before them and on their right hands; they shall say: Our Lord! make perfect for us our light, and grant us protection, surely Thou hast power over all things.

7. See: F. b. Tabrisi 1372 Sh.

8. The full Verse states the following:

﴿وَالَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوَالَهُمْ رِئَاءَ النَّاسِ وَلَا يُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَلَا بِالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ ۚ وَمَن يَكُنِ الشَّيْطَانُ لَهُ قَرِينًا فَسَاءَ قَرِينًا ۝﴾

And those who spend their property (in alms) to be seen of the people and do not believe in Allah nor in the last day; and as for him whose associate is the Shaitan, an evil associate is he!

9. Translation of Yusuf Ali:

Allah doth wish to lighten your [difficulties:] For man was created weak in resolution.

The same mistakes exist in this translation.

10. The full Verse states the following:

﴿۱۰﴾ وَابْتَلُوا الْيَتَامَىٰ حَتَّىٰ إِذَا بَلَغُوا النِّكَاحَ فَإِنْ آنَسْتُمْ مِنْهُمْ رُشْدًا فَادْفَعُوا إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوَالَهُمْ ﴿۱۱﴾ وَلَا تَأْكُلُوهَا إِسْرَافًا وَبِدَارًا أَنْ يَكْبَرُوا ﴿۱۲﴾ وَمَنْ كَانَ غَنِيًّا فَلْيَسْتَعْفِفْ وَمَنْ كَانَ فَقِيرًا فَلْيَأْكُلْ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ ﴿۱۳﴾ فَإِذَا دَفَعْتُمْ إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوَالَهُمْ فَأَشْهَدُوا عَلَيْهِمْ ﴿۱۴﴾ وَكَفَىٰ بِاللَّهِ حَسِيبًا

And test the orphans until they attain puberty; then if you find in them maturity of intellect, make over to them their property, and do not consume it extravagantly and hastily, lest they attain to full age; and whoever is rich, let him abstain altogether, and whoever is poor, let him eat reasonably; then when you make over to them their property, call witnesses in their presence; and Allah is enough as a Reckoner.

[11.](#) The full Verse states the following:

قَالُوا ادْعُ لَنَا رَبَّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَنَا مَا هِيَ إِنَّ الْبَقَرَ تَشَابَهَ عَلَيْنَا وَإِنَّا إِن شَاءَ اللَّهُ لَمُهْتَدُونَ

They said: Call on your Lord for our sake to make it plain to us what she is, for surely to us the cows are all alike, and if Allah please we shall surely be guided aright.

[12.](#) The full Verse states the following:

وَلَتَجِدَنَّهُمْ أَحْرَصَ النَّاسِ عَلَىٰ حَيَاةٍ وَمِنَ الَّذِينَ أَشْرَكُوا ﴿۱﴾ يُودُّ أَحَدُهُمْ لَوْ يُعْمَرُ أَلْفَ سَنَةٍ وَمَا هُوَ بِمُزَحِّزٍهُ مِنَ الْعَذَابِ أَنْ يُعْمَرَ ﴿۲﴾ وَاللَّهُ بِصِيرٍ بِمَا يَعْمَلُونَ

And you will most certainly find them the greediest of men for life (greedier) than even those who are polytheists; every one of them loves that he should be granted a life of a thousand years, and his being granted a long life will in no way remove him further off from the chastisement, and Allah sees what they do.

[1] [1]

SHARES

Chapter 4: Solution

Solution

The issue of translating the Qur'an into English has been a matter of controversy since it was decided to translate the Qur'an into English. In the first chapter, we stated that the translating of the Qur'an has opponents and supporters and each of has their own reasons for their claims.

There have been key issues in the translating of the Qur'an. First of all, the source and target languages, i.e., Arabic and English, are two different languages coming from different cultures. In addition, the language of the Qur'an has been a matter of debate, some scholars believe it is literary, while others believe it is mystical, mysterious, classical, etc. This is important because if someone believes that the language of the Qur'an is, for example, mysterious, he will translate it in a mysterious way. This has a key role on how the Qur'an's message is conveyed to its audience. Furthermore, some of the wordings and structures used by the Qur'an are difficult. In this thesis, we have attempted to find a solution to convey the message of the Qur'an to English as complete as possible. Two subjects must be considered when translating the Qur'an, the language of the Qur'an and the objective of the translator.

According to the Qur'an, its objective is to convey its message as complete as possible, for instance:

هذا بَيَانٌ لِلنَّاسِ

This is an explanation for mankind (3: 138).

This verse says that the Qur'an is explanation to all the mankind. Hence, the wordings and structures are clear and the meaning is understandable for mankind. The translation should be the same.

Some verses invite people to understand the message of the Qur'an, for instance:

انْظُرْ كَيْفَ نَصَرَفُ الْآيَاتِ لَعَلَّهُمْ يَفْقَهُونَ

See how We explain the signs by various [symbols]; that they may understand. (6:65).

How is it possible to understand the messages of the Qur'an if the verses become complicated? Complication can become so extreme that understanding the text becomes impossible.

Another issue that must be solved is language of the Qur'an. Obviously, those who believe that the language of the Qur'an is mysterious will give a mysterious translation too. Similarly, those who believe that the language of the Qur'an is literary will present a literally translation. The examples apply to other approaches to.

The takeaway is that one's approach to the Qur'an will define how the holy text is translated. We believe that the language of the Qur'an is a special language very close to standard Arabic. Therefore, the Qur'an must be translated using Standard English too, in order to convey its message as complete as possible, because:

The text of the Qur'an is very close to the standard style of Saudi Arabian writing, even when compared to modern writings e.g., Al Arabiyah bayna Yadayk.

The Qur'an itself says that it uses a clear Arabic language:

بِلِسَانٍ عَرَبِيٍّ مُبِينٍ

In a clear Arabic language (36: 195).

The messengers of God spoke and taught in the language of their target society. Naturally, the language people used was the standard language that all understood. The teachings of religions were for all the people of the society, not for an exclusive class of people, so the translations should be in standard language too.

وَمَا أَرْسَلْنَا مِنْ رَّسُولٍ إِلَّا بِلِسَانٍ قَوْمِهِ لِيُبَيِّنَ لَهُمْ فَيُضِلُّ اللَّهُ مَنْ يَشَاءُ وَ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشَاءُ وَ هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ

And We did not send any messenger but with the language of his people, so that he might explain to them clearly. Then Allah leads astray whomever He wishes, and He guides whomsoever He wishes, and He is the All-mighty, the All-wise (14:4).

Accordingly, if we want to convey the message of the Qur'an as complete as possible, we should use structures of Standard English and refrain from complicating the translation by using non-standard structures. We must also consider whether the wordings used in the source have equivalents in the target language. If so, they can be used, otherwise, their meaning should be translated in the text or footnote. Words that are exclusive to the Qur'an, should be transliterated and their meaning clarified in the footnote in Standard English on the basis of commentaries. Thus, we classify our solution according to what we have said as follows:

Wordings of the Qur'an are constituted from two parts: words and expressions. The words are classified in three parts:

1) Have Equivalents

Have equivalents: such as pronouns e.g. **أنا** meaning "I"

It's easy to translate these words because an equivalent exists in Standard English.

Words with no equivalent in the target language due to being exclusive to the Qur'an, such as Qisas, K'abah, Qiblah, taqwa and so on. Translators must refrain from creating equivalents for this category because no word can adequately reflect their meaning. Instead, these words should be transliterated and their meaning clarified in the footnotes.

Words which have several meanings. They are called difficult words because most of the translators translated them literally and feared to write their meaning according to the context, thus, they have complicated the translation. We suggest that these words should be translated according to their meaning in the text and commentaries of the Qur'an without any fear, otherwise we will complicate the meaning and the message will not be conveyed.

E.g. **تَحْتَ**

The word (**تَحْتَ**: taht) literally means under, beneath, but literal translation of this word in some verses may cause ambiguity, such as verses: 2:25; 2:266; 3: 15; 3: 136; 3: 195; 3: 198; 4: 13; 4:57; 4: 122; 5: 12; 5:85; 5: 119; 9:72; 13:35.

The word (**تَحْتَ**: taht) literally means under, but translating it literally causes ambiguity in some verses, for instance, 2:25, 266–3: 15, 136, 195, 198– 4: 13, 57, 122; 5: 12, 85, 119, 9:72, 13:35.

One example has been examined below:

جَنَّاتٌ عَدْنٌ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ

In Surah Ta Ha, 20:76.

If (تَحْتِ: taht) is translated literally, the meaning of the verse will not be correct. For instance, ‘there are rivers under the gardens’ is wrong, the verse is actually saying ‘gardens through which rivers flow’. Therefore, in order to avoid complication in this category we should refrain from translating literally.

2) Expressions

This group consists of the most difficult phrases of the Qur'an. We have chosen these phrases because they are like expressions and proverb, therefore, the literal meaning of these phrases makes no sense. Therefore, this group must be translated either by using expressions with a similar meaning in the target language or to translate the meaning itself.

e.g.

تَذْهَبَ رِيحُكُمْ

In Surah Al-Anfal, 8:46.

رِيحٌ literally means smell or wind, but in this phrase the literal meaning is not intended. Most classic commentators believe this expression means: power and position¹, so this sentence, i.e. (تَذْهَبَ رِيحُكُمْ), means to lose your unity, power, and strength.

3) Difficult Structures

Structures that are exclusive to Arabic, such as Tamyiz and Ma'f'uli mutlaq. The difficulty is because they are exclusive to Arabic and we are not allowed to use these structures in Standard English. Rather, we should use structures that already exist in Standard English.

e.g. Surah Al-Fajr, 89:21:

كَلَّا إِذَا دُكَّتِ الْأَرْضُ دَكًّا دَكًّا

Nay! When the earth is pounded to powder.

If we say that دَكًّا is Ma'f'uli mutlaq takidi, it should not be repeated in the translation, instead another word must be used to show emphasis, such as strongly and severely, or a verb such as crush and pounder.

[1.](#) See: Tabrisi 1372 Sh.

[1] [1]

SHARES

Bibliography

Alusi, Mahmud b. ʿAbd Allah al-. 1415 A.H. Ruh al-maʿani fi tafsir al-Qurʿan al-ʿazim. Beirut: Dar al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya.

Andulusi, Abu Hayyan Muhammad b. Yusuf al-. 1420 A.H. Al-Bahr al-muhit fi l-tafsir. Beirut: Dar al-Fikr.

Arberry, Arthur J., 1955. The Koran Interpreted. New York: Macmillan 4.

Ardabili, Seyyed ʿAbd al-Karim, 1375 Sh. Mushkel ma dar fahme quran, Nameyeh mufid, n 8.

ʿArusi al-Huwayzi, ʿAbd ʿAli al-. 1415 A.H. Tafsir nur al-thaqalayn. Qom: Ismaʿilian.

Azartash Azarnush, etc, 1389sh. Tarjumah Quran mabani nazari va siri tarikhi. Tehran: Nashr kitab jamiʿ.

Baghawi, Husayn b. Masʿud al-. 1420 A.H. Maʿalim al-tanzil fi l-tafsir al-Qurʿan. Beirut: Dar Ihyaʿ Turath al-ʿArabi.

Baghdadi, ʿAlaʿ al-Din ʿAli b. Muhammad al-. 1415 A.H. Lubab al-taʿwil fi maʿani al-tanzil. Beirut: Dar al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya.

Bahrampur, Abu l-Fadhl, trans. 1392 Sh. Qurʿan Karim. Qom: Chapkhani-y-i Buzurg-i Qurʿan Karim.

Bahrani, al-Sayyid Hashim al-. 1995. Al-Burhan fi tafsir al-Qurʿan. 1st. Tehran: Bunyad-i Biʿthat.

Balaghi, Muhammad Jawad al-. 1420 A.H. Alaʿ al-rahman fi tafsir al-Qurʿan. Qom: Bunyad-i Biʿthat.

Baydhawi, ʿAbd Allah b. ʿUmar al-. 1418 A.H. Anwar al-tanzil wa asrar al-taʿawil. Beirut: Dar Ihyaʿ al-Turath al-ʿArabi.

Biazar Shirazi, ʿAbd al-karim. 1376 Sh. Quran natiq. Vol. 1. Tehran: Daftari Nashri Farhanqi Islami.

Dakhil, ʿAli b. Muhammad ʿAli. 1422 A.H. Al-Wajiz fi tafsir al-kitab al-ʿaziz. Beirut: Dar al-Taʿaruf li l-Matbuʿat.

Dhahabi, Muhammad Husayn al- 1396 AH. Al-Tafsir wa al- Mufasssirun. Qahirah: Dar al- Kutub al-Hadithiyah.

Fadhli al–Allah, Muhammad Husayn. 1419 A.H. Min wahy al–Qur'an. Beirut: Dar al–Milak.

Farahidi, Khalil Ibn Ahmad. 1410 AH. Al–I'yn. Qom: Intisharati Hijrat.

Faydh al–Kashani, Muhsin al–. 1415 A.H. Tafsir al–safi. Tehran: Intisharat al–Fadr.

Faydhi, Abu l–Faydh. 1417 A.H. Sawati al–ilham fi tafsir al–Qur'an. Qom: Dar al–Manar.

Fuladwand, Muhammad Mahdi, trans. 1418 A.H. Qur'an Karim. Tehran: Daftar–i Mutali'at–i Tarikh wa Ma'arif–i Islami.

Ha'iri Tihrani, Mir Sayyid Ali. 1377 Sh. Muqtaniyat al–durar wa multaqitat al–thamar. Tehran: Dar al–Kutub al–Islamiyya.

Hasakani, Ubayd Allah b. Abd Allah al–. 1411 A.H. Shawahid al–tanzil li qawa'id al–tafdhil. Tehran: Mu'assasa al–Tab' wa l–Nashr.

Ibn Abi Hatam, Abd al–Rahman b. Muhammad. 1419 A.H. Tafsir al–Qur'an al–azim. Riyadh: Maktaba al–Nazzar Mus'afa al–Baz.

Ibn Ajiba, Ahmad b. Muhmmad. 1419 A.H. Al–Bahr al–madid fi tafsir al–Qur'an al–majid. Cairo: Hasan Abbas Zaki.

Ibn al–Jawzi, Abd al–Rahman b. Ali. 1422 A.H. Zad al–masir fi ilm al–tafsir. Beirut: Dar al–Kutub al–Arabi.

Ibn Ashur, Muhammad b. Tahir. 1405 A.H. Al–Tahrir wa l–tanwir. Beirut: Mu'assasa al–Tarikh al–Arabi.

Ibn Kathir, Isma'il b. Umar. 1419 A.H. Tafsir al–Qur'an al–azim. Beirut: Dar al–Kutub al–Ilmiyya.

Ilahi Qumshiqi, Mahdi, trans. 1380 Sh. Qur'an Karim. Qom: Fatima al–Zahra.

Isfahani, Muhammad Ali. 1391 Sh. Mantiq Tarjomah: Qom: Markazi Biynulmilali Tarjumah wa Nashri al–Mustafa

Kashani, Fath Allah. n.d. Khulasat al–minhaj. Tehran: Islamiyya.

—. 1336 SH. MinHajj al–sadiqin fi ilzam al–mukhalifin. Tehran: Kitab Furushi Muhammad Hasan A'ami.

Makarim Shirazi, Nasir, trans. 1373 Sh. Qur'an Karim. Qom: Dar al–Qur'an al–Karim.

—. 1374 Sh. Tafsir–i Nimuni. Tehran: Dar al–Kutub al–Islamiyya.

Maybudi, Rashid al–Din Ahmad al–. 1371 Sh. Kashf al–asrar wa uddat al–abrar. Tehran: Amir Kabir.

Mishkini Ardabili, ﷺ Ali, trans. 1381 Sh. Qur'an Karim. Qom: Nashr al-Hadi.

Mustafaw, Hasan, 1360 Sh. Al- tahqiq fi kalamati qu ﷺ ran al- karim. Tehran: Bungahi Tarjumah wa Nashri Kitab.

Mughniyah, Muhammad Jawad. 1424 A.H. Kashif. Tehran: Dar al-kutub al-Islamiyya.

Muhalla, Jalal al-Din, and Suyuti Jalal al-Din al-. 1416 A.H. Jalalayn. Beirut: al-Nur li l-Matbu'at.

Muqatil b. Sulayman al-. 1423 A.H. Tafsir Muqatil b. Sulayman. Beirut: Dar Ihya' al-Turath.

Musawi al-Sabziwari, al-Sayyid ﷺ Abd al-ﷺ A'la al-. 1409 A.H. Mawahib al-rahman fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Beirut: Mu'assasa Ahl al-Bayt.

Nakhjawani, N'imat Allah b. Mahmud. 1999. Al-Fawatih al-ilahiyya wa l-mafatih al-ghaybiyya. Egypt: Dar Rikabi li l-Nashr.

Najjar. Ali, 1381AHS. Usul wa Mabani Tarjomah: Rasht: Intisharat Kitab Mubin.

Nasr, Seyyed Hossein. 2016. The Study Qur'an. New York: HarperCollins Publishers Inc.

Pickthall, Muhammad Marmaduke, n.d. The Meaning of the Glorious Koran. New York.

Qara'i, ﷺ Ali Quli, trans. 2004. The Qur'an with phrase-by-phrase English translation. ICAS Press.

Qummi, ﷺ Ali b. Ibrahim al-. 1367 Sh. Tafsir al-Qummi. Qom: Dar al-Kitab.

Qurashshi, Siyyid Aliakbar, 1371 Sh. Qamusi, Tehran: Dar al- Kutub al- Islamiya.

Qurtubi, Muhammad b. Ahmad al-. 1364 Sh. Al-Jami' li ahkam al-Qur'an. Tehran: Intisharat-i Nasir Khusraw.

Raghib Isfahani, Husayn Ibn Muhammad. 1412 A.H. Al- Mufradat fi gharib al-:Beyrut: Dar al- 'Ilm Dar al- Shamiyyah.

Raghib Isfahani, Husayn Ibn Muhammad. 1412 A.H. Al- Mufradat fi gharib al-. Biyrut: Dar al-'Ilm Dar al- Shamiyyah.

Razi, Abu l-Futuh Husayn b. ﷺ Ali al-. 1408 A.H. Rawdh al-jinan wa ruh al-jinan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Mashhad: Astan-i Quds-i Radhawi.

Razi, Fakhr al-Din al-. 1420 A.H. Mafatih al-ghayb. 3rd Edition. 32 vols. Beirut: Dar Ihya' Turath al-ﷺ Arabi.

Sabziwari al-Najafi, Muhammad b. Habib Allah al-. 1406 A.H. Al-Jadid fi tafsir al-Qur'an al-majid.

Beirut: Dar al-Taʿaruf li l-Matbuʿat.

Saʿdi, ʿAbd al-Rhman b. Nasir al-. 1408 A.H. Taysir al-karim al-rahman fi tafsir al-kalam al-mannan. Beirut: Maktab al-Nahdha al-ʿArabiyya.

ʿAdiqi, Muhammad. 1419 A.H. Al-Balagh fi tafsir al-Qur'an bi l-Qur'an. Tehran.

—. 1406 A.H. Al-Furqan fi tafsir al-Qur'an bi l-Qur'an wa l-sunna. Tehran: Daftar-i Nashr-i Farhang-i Islami.

ʿAffarzadih, Tahiri, trans. 1380 Sh. Qur'an Karim. Muʿassisi-y-i Farhangi-y-i Jahan Rayani-y-i Kawthar.

Sarwar, Muhammad, trans. 1981. The Holy Qur'an. Elmhurst.

Shakir, Muhammadkazim, 1389 sh, Mabani va ravishhayi tafsir, Markazi Biynulmilali Tarjumah va Nashri al-Mustafa.

Suyuti, Jalal al-Din al-. 1404 A.H. Al-Durr al-manthur fi tafsir al-maʿthur. Qom: Maktaba Ayatullah al-Marʿashi al-Najafi.

Tabarani, Sulayman B. Ahmad al-. 2008. Al-Tafsir al-kabir. Irbid: Dar al-Kitab al-Thighafiyya.

Tabari, Muhammad b. Jarir al-. 1412 A.H. Jamiʿ al-bayan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Beirut: Dar al-Maʿrifa.

Tabatabaʿi, al-Sayyid Muhammad Husayn al-. 1417 A.H. Al-Mizan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. 5th. Qom: Daftar-i Intisharat-i Islami.

Tabrisi, Fadhl b. Hasan al-. 1372 Sh. Majmaʿ al-bayan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Tehran: Intisharat-i Nasir Khusraw.

Tayyib, Sayyid ʿAbd al-Husayn al-. 1378 A.H. Atyab al-Bayan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Tehran: Dar al-Islam.

Thaʿalibi, ʿAbd al-Rhman b. Muhammad al-. 1418 A.H. Jawahir al-hisan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Beirut: Dar Ihyaʿ al-Turath al-ʿArabi.

Thaʿlabi al-Niyshaburi, Abu Ishaq Ahmad b. Ibrahim al-. 1422 A.H. Al-Kashf wa l-bayan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Beirut: Dar Ihyaʿ al-Turath al-ʿArabi.

Tusi, Muhammad b. Hasan al-. 1405 A.H. Al-Tibyan fi tafsir al-Qur'an. Beirut: Dar Ihyaʿ al-Turath al-ʿArabi.

Tustari, Abu Muhammad SAhl b. ʿAbd Allah al-. 1423 A.H. Tafsir al-Tustari. Beirut: Dar al-kutub al-ʿIlmiyya.

Yusuf Ali, Abdullah. 1995. The Meaning of the Holy Qur'an. Medina.

Zamakhshari, Mahmud al-. 1986. Al-Kashshaf ʿan haqāʾiq ghawamidh al-tanzil. Beirut: Dar al-Kitab al-ʿArabi.

[1] [1]

SHARES

Source URL:

<https://www.al-islam.org/study-lexicons-and-structures-english-translations-quran-behrouz-foroutan>

Links

[1] <https://www.addtoany.com/share>

[2] <https://www.al-islam.org/person/behrouz-foroutan>

[3] <https://www.al-islam.org/printpdf/book/export/html/158865>

[4] <https://www.al-islam.org/printepub/book/export/html/158865>

[5] <https://www.al-islam.org/printmobi/book/export/html/158865>

[6] <https://www.al-islam.org/tags/quran>